

Chapter 15

Reaching the World



News media is an important part of any modern society, from local newspapers to national television stations to the global internet. Today, the dissemination of information and opinion is easier, and therefore more accessible, than at any point in human history, but this comes with both benefits and drawbacks.

For much of the past few centuries, the format of media and the largest media outlets have been dominated by the West. But even more fundamentally, the basic language of information and media, especially on the internet, is undeniably English. While this is not, in and of itself, something that denies access to the non-Anglophone world, it limits the ability of non-English speakers to express themselves and for their ideas, hopes, and dreams to reach English-speaking audiences.

For me, as a Chinese think tanker, and for the Center for China and Globalization, this is an especially challenging realm to navigate. The abundance of misinformation or biased reporting in the majority of Western English-language media, as well as the lack of accurate, comprehensive assessments of China's history and current stage of development, mean that far from being able to discuss core issues that China could potentially contribute to, we are often faced with the task of dispelling concerns, correcting inaccurate information or informing people around the world about China's actual situation.

In the final chapter of this collection, we have compiled some of my most recent interviews with media outlets ranging from television stations in Hong Kong, China, India, and Türkiye to print media from Korea and Slovenia and even the "Living History" project initiated by the United States Consulate in Shanghai. The broad and balanced nature of these interactions is also fundamental to CCG's mission of ensuring that a wide net is cast in sharing and promoting China's positions, its achievements, and hopes for the future, not only for itself but also for the world.

The first interview in this section is with *Choson Ilbo*, South Korea's oldest newspaper, as part of a series of interviews commemorating the 80th anniversary of the end of World War II. Following Japan's surrender, the separation of Korea after the Korean War and the founding of the People's Republic of China created a dynamic

in Northeast Asia that is fraught with complex and unresolved issues. The presence of US troops in both South Korea and Japan, China's close relations with North Korea, and the yet-to-be-reunified island of Taiwan mean that relations between these nations are inextricably linked with the United States and the post-war paradigm that it led. However, what is different is that China has a greater ability and, therefore, responsibility to take a greater role in how the region develops in the future and to ensure its overall peace and prosperity.

The second interview, with Hong Kong-based Television Broadcasts Limited (TVB), moves south to focus on India and a visit by Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi that came just before a key meeting of the Shanghai Cooperation Organization in early September 2025, which was also attended by President Putin of Russia. The complex relationship between China and India has long been difficult to balance and recent conflicts, despite being limited in their scope and severity, have strained relations. India's participation in both BRICS, and the Quad adds to the difficulty of balancing relations between the world's two most populous countries. But the potential for positive development is considerable, considering recent tariffs levied by the United States and China's continued efforts at reconciliation.

The next interview, this time from the Indian media outlet Republic TV, looks at the visit by Prime Minister Modi from a different, decidedly Indian, perspective. It covers a range of topics from the recent conflict between India and Pakistan, a close ally of China, as well as the possibility of BRICS as an organization to stand up to the United States on the issue of tariffs, as well as possible positive steps that China and India could make going forward, not only to improve their own bilateral relations but also to create an environment in the region that is conducive to stability and increased trade.

The fourth interview in this chapter is from the English-language services of the national broadcaster of Türkiye—TRT World. While this interview once again focuses on US tariffs and other pressure, which China feels is tantamount to outright bullying, the emphasis was rather on the fact that China has kept the doors to dialogue wide open. The fact that trade wars benefit no one, especially in a world where the economies of so many countries are so intertwined and any chance to talk things out would ensure that both the United States and China benefit. The interview also touched on Israel's actions in Gaza and the instability and suffering that it has caused, discussing the changing nature of America's reputation in the world as well as the need to establish a peacekeeping force through the UN to bring stability back to the Middle East.

Taking a closer look at the situation in the Middle East, the next interview in this chapter is from Al Jazeera's "The Bottom Line" program, which wanted to gain a deeper insight into China's view on Israel's war on Gaza. China recently brokered a historic agreement between Iran and Saudi Arabia, which had long been unable to resolve their differences. This has been attributed to China's unique position in the world and alternative approach to negotiations and peacemaking, which could also be effective in finding an offramp to hostilities in Gaza as well as Ukraine. China not only lacks the historical baggage of the United States and Europe in these conflicts, but it also emphasizes effectively leveraging multilateral institutions, from the United

Nations to the G7, G20, and even BRICS to foster peace and find areas of common ground.

China has long been a staunch supporter of a more multilateral world order that gives equal weight to developing and smaller nations. This next interview was conducted on the sidelines of the Bled Strategic Forum in Slovenia by the RTV Slovenija. The Bled Strategic Forum is unique in that it is held in, and what is generally considered a smaller country that is not often in the global spotlight, however, it is exactly this aspect of the Forum that gives it a unique perspective on issues, which allows it to surface often underdiscussed perspectives on vital issues.

In a world where China-related issues often have regional or even global implications, and the conclusion of the next issue is particularly appropriate—namely, the fact that a more open China is a more secure China. In this interview with Phoenix News on the sidelines of 2024 Aspen Security Forum, topics on how policies that isolate and alienate China from the global discussion could have destructive consequences. The “small yard high fence” strategy of the United States in terms of semiconductors and other essential technologies will ultimately end up forcing China to develop its own alternatives and cause the United States to lose a key market. Similar problems also exist in geopolitics. Not working with China on issues including Taiwan and other regional issues will only make China’s stance more rigid, whereas engagement and open communication would create an environment where China is more open to negotiation and compromise.

The different systems, histories, and even values that exist in China and the West are often a point of contention that requires time and effort to understand and accept. This is the core topic of the eighth interview in this chapter with *Delo*, Slovenia’s largest newspaper, which was also conducted in conjunction with the Bled Strategic Forum. While there is an onus on China to work to better express itself in an international context, considering the language barriers, cultural differences, and systemic complexities that China faces, it is also important for leaders and decision-makers unfamiliar with China to work to better understand it through dialogue and exchange at all levels, from government to institutions and people-to-people exchanges.

The last interview in this chapter focuses on my own journey of personal and professional growth, from the dark, difficult times of the late Cultural Revolution, the light and hope of a university education and studying abroad, as well as the trials and successes of an incredibly exciting cross-cultural career. It was an honor to be interviewed by the “Living History” documentary series, supported through the US Consulate in Shanghai, which attempts to record the period from 1979 to 2010 through the personal experiences of individuals from all walks of life. Without being overly self-congratulatory, I have experienced nearly every aspect of China’s recent history, received education in both China and the West, and worked in governments and major multinationals on both sides of the Pacific, finally founding my own think tank with the vision to continue what I feel to be the most important lesson of my life—to foster dialogue wherever possible and ensure that the people of all nations come to understand and accept each other on their own terms to ensure a better future for all mankind.

80 Years on—Northeast Asia’s Past and Future¹

On August 12, 2025, Henry Huiyao Wang, Founder and President of the Center for China and Globalization (CCG), gave an interview to *Chosun Ilbo*, South Korea’s largest daily newspaper. Their discussion examined the transformations in Northeast Asia over the past eight decades, during which Wang shared his perspectives on China’s role in reshaping the international order and on broader trends in global development.

Founded in 1920 and headquartered in Seoul, the *Chosun Ilbo* is South Korea’s oldest and most widely circulated daily newspaper. This interview formed a central part of the paper’s special series marking the 80th anniversary of the end of World War II and was featured in its dedicated China section. The piece appeared both in print and on the newspaper’s official website.

Part I US-China Relations and the Global Order

Chosun Ilbo: You are now one of the most prominent experts on US-China relations. How should we assess the current easing of tensions between the two countries? For example, today it was announced that the United States and China have extended their tariff “truce period” by 90 days. How do you view the overall situation?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I believe US-China relations are essentially a relationship of interdependence and shared prosperity. Over the past eight years, spanning Donald Trump’s first and current presidential terms, through continued engagement with China and multiple rounds of trade war maneuvering, the United States has come to fully recognize a reality long understood in China: “I am in you and you are in me.” In truth, it is very difficult to separate the two.

That is why I think Trump has adopted a more pragmatic approach this time. He agreed with China to extend the suspension of tariff measures. Whether in Geneva, where talks pushed for tariff reductions, in London, where both sides sought to maintain the status quo and clarify differences, or in Stockholm, where the latest discussions were held, this trend has been evident. Today’s announcement of a further 90-day extension of the tariff truce likely serves to create room for a leaders’ summit, enabling further progress in the three months ahead.

My view stems from China’s unique position. In America’s dealings with major global trading partners and economies, China’s advantages and weight are increasingly pronounced. Within global supply chains, China plays a pivotal role: 80 percent of iPhones are produced in China; half of Tesla’s electric vehicles are manufactured there; and a significant share of auto parts, particularly those needed by US companies, also comes from Chinese suppliers. Beyond this, China is the holder of irreplaceable strategic resources such as rare earths.

¹ The interview was conducted in Chinese, and the Chinese transcript is available on CCG’s official WeChat blog. The English translation of the transcript has not been reviewed by either of the speakers.

Therefore, if the United States continues to stoke trade wars in these areas, it no longer holds the same leverage as before. A better approach is for both sides to sit down and negotiate, identify common ground, and strike a balance. For instance, China can step up purchases of US agricultural products, especially soybeans. As Trump recently emphasized, he wants China to buy more American soybeans, and that is entirely feasible. At the same time, the United States could consider easing restrictions on China in the semiconductor sector. After all, these restrictions not only affect US firms but also chipmakers in South Korea, Japan, the Netherlands, and elsewhere.

In this light, the consensus to continue suspending the 24 percent tariffs sends a positive signal. Particularly as Trump prepares to advance peace talks between Russia and Ukraine, he needs tangible economic and trade achievements to showcase progress. Against this backdrop, breakthroughs in US-China economic talks would undoubtedly inject stability into the global landscape and provide the world with a much-needed reassurance.

Chosun Ilbo: In South Korea and Japan, some commentators argue that the tariff war launched by Trump is not only long-lasting, but that most of the so-called “victim countries” are actually US allies, such as South Korea and Japan. By contrast, China, though in a confrontational stance with the United States, appears in some ways to have emerged relatively better off. Do you think the fundamental reason lies only in differences of power, or are there other factors at play?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I think Trump is a relatively pragmatic leader. He likely believes that in international relations today, “power” remains the decisive factor. That is why he has imposed high tariffs on India, the European Union, Japan, and South Korea—economies that, compared with the US, still show a clear overall gap in strength. China, however, is in a somewhat different position. This April, after our National Day, Trump briefly raised tariffs on Chinese goods to as high as 245 percent, but he quickly announced exemptions covering \$100 billion worth of Chinese products, including smartphones, computers, and semiconductors. These categories are closely tied to production by US companies in China. Apple and Tesla, for example, depend heavily on China, while roughly 60 percent of Walmart’s global procurement also originates there.

In addition, the United States has repeatedly escalated its chip export controls against China citing “national security,” which no doubt sets a precedent. In response, China has the option to reciprocate, “treating others the way they treat you.” For instance, rare earth materials, which are vital for US defense and security industries, could be subject to measured restrictions from China, sending a clear signal. If the two sides fully confront each other in this domain, the United States would deeply feel the weight of China’s influence.

At the same time, Trump still seeks to reshape the international order and continue his broader plan to “Make America Great Again.” He does not want excessive pressure on China to undermine his global strategic agenda. After all, he is advancing new initiatives in Canada, Greenland, and Panama; pushing US-led processes in the Middle East; pursuing strategic arrangements in the Caucasus, even brokering a

peace deal between Azerbaijan and Armenia; and, of course, aiming to play a central role in the Russia-Ukraine war. With so many parallel priorities, he cannot afford to make enemies on all fronts at once.

China, as America's principal "strategic competitor"—at least in Washington's eyes—may therefore see some restrictions eased or at least find Trump more willing to reach certain agreements, out of considerations of power and strategy. Such moves reflect Trump's pragmatism and also serve his larger ambition of reshaping the global economic and trade order.

Chosun Ilbo: So, what exactly is Trump trying to reshape? What do you think is the ultimate goal or outcome of this "reshaping"?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Trump's "reshaping" rests on his belief that the United States has been "taken advantage of" under the current international system. In his view, America has been losing out in the international trade order built over nearly 80 years since World War II. He argues that US manufacturing has been hollowed out, and that the Midwest and the middle class have suffered severe blows. But these claims are not entirely accurate. In fact, in many ways, the United States has been the biggest beneficiary of the post-war system.

The United States still ranks first globally in GDP, with a population of over 300 million and extraordinary natural endowments. Its continental territory stretches between the Atlantic and Pacific, giving it unmatched geographic advantages. The United Nations headquarters is in New York, giving the US unique influence in global governance. Overall, the United States has been the primary beneficiary of this system.

Nevertheless, Trump wants to rewrite or even overturn that order in pursuit of a new strategic design. His goal is to shift from multilateralism toward unilateralism, because he believes America still has the power to "do it alone." In dealing with China, he exercises more caution; with other countries and regions, he feels less constrained. His core aim is "America First": to maximize US interests and preserve the advantages the country has enjoyed for the past 80 years. In his eyes, America is no longer as comfortably dominant as it once was, so he seeks to craft a new strategy that maximizes US gains and ensures America remains at the helm of global affairs.

Chosun Ilbo: Building on what you just mentioned—that China's overall national strength has risen significantly and now approaches that of the United States—how would you quantify this? From the perspective of political, economic, and diplomatic strength, what percentage of US power would you say China has reached?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I would say that in terms of soft power, China still lags behind the United States. China's GDP now approaches 70 percent of America's, but when it comes to soft power, the United States retains clear advantages. For example, English is the global lingua franca, giving the United States inherent global influence. Many international organizations are headquartered there, with the United Nations in New York being the most prominent example. The United States also maintains dominance in global media, news, and publishing, all fundamental pillars of soft power.

That said, it is also important to note that while the United States was the primary driver of economic globalization for much of the past seven or eight decades, that role is increasingly being taken up by China. China's soft power is now closely linked to its promotion of globalization and international cooperation. For instance, the creation of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) has provided an important complement to the World Bank and the IMF. The Belt and Road Initiative has generated cooperation agreements with more than 150 countries, building a vast network of international economic partnerships. China has also gradually emerged as a leader of the Global South, working alongside India at the core of mechanisms such as BRICS.

BRICS itself is an inclusive economic cooperation platform, essentially an "economic club." Its membership spans a wide range of governance systems: from India, often described as the "world's largest democracy," to monarchies in the Middle East. BRICS does not draw lines along ideological divisions; it focuses squarely on economic cooperation and inclusiveness. Even India and Pakistan can sit at the same table. This model emphasizes shared economic benefits and development, offering a new paradigm for international cooperation.

China also plays a proactive and leading role in multilateral engagement. It is part of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP), the world's largest free trade agreement. It has also expressed interest in joining the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership (CPTPP). Regionally, China has promoted the China-ASEAN Business and Investment Summit and invited Gulf states into the ASEAN-GCC-China dialogue framework. Beyond Asia, China has created cooperation forums with Latin America, Africa, Central Asia, and the Arab world, covering nearly all major international cooperation networks.

Taken together, these initiatives highlight how quickly China's strength has grown in promoting economic globalization, infrastructure development, and global development.

Chosun Ilbo: Looking ahead, what do you think China will focus on in terms of soft power?

Henry Huiyao Wang: The next step for China is to continue safeguarding and advancing economic globalization, to build what can be called "Globalization 2.0." The post-World War II international order, anchored in the United Nations system over the past 80 years, represents what we might call "Globalization 1.0." What China is now promoting represents a transition toward an upgraded "2.0" version.

"Globalization 2.0" means building on the existing foundations of international cooperation while placing greater emphasis on deepening and expanding economic globalization, as well as strengthening cultural and people-to-people exchanges. The goal is to foster broader interaction and integration among nations in economic, cultural, and other spheres. As Deng Xiaoping emphasized, "development is the hard truth." For all developing countries, development remains the most fundamental and urgent task. In this process, China is set to play a pivotal role, serving as a backbone, a center, and a driving force for the wider developing world.

I believe China is not only setting an example in advancing economic globalization but also leading a new round of it. By stimulating development in surrounding countries and across wider regions and by becoming the leading trading partner for more than 140 countries and regions, China has ample space and opportunities to continue shaping the next stage of global integration.

Chosun Ilbo: The United States seeks to maintain global hegemony. Do you agree with the view that there is now a vacuum in global leadership?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I do not believe there is a vacuum in global leadership. In fact, the world is undergoing a transition from a “unipolar” to a “multipolar” system. What we are witnessing today is the historical process of multipolarization.

In this multipolar world, beyond the United States, there are also China, the European Union, India, and other major regional powers or regional integration organizations, as well as important economies like the BRICS countries. Together, they are exploring and shaping new systems of global governance. In this transformation, China has demonstrated unique advantages. In promoting economic globalization and international cooperation, China has often acted ahead of the United States and other nations. At the same time, the United States in recent years has scaled back its support for developing countries, even shutting down USAID programs, whereas China has continued to expand its investment and engagement.

From the perspective of global governance and economic cooperation, therefore, China enjoys a notable competitive edge in today’s multipolar landscape.

Part II How China Views South Korea

Chosun Ilbo: Let’s turn to some questions about South Korea. Since our newspaper is preparing a special feature on the 80th anniversary of the post-war era, how would you assess South Korea’s development path over the past 80 years? From your perspective as a Chinese expert on global affairs, what is your view?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I would say South Korea’s development has been highly successful. It is one of the most representative success stories of the “Globalization 1.0” era. After World War II, Western Europe achieved rapid growth under the Marshall Plan. Following the Korean War, both South Korea and Japan began their fast development, while after the Vietnam War, the Asian “Four Tigers” quickly rose. In this context, South Korea benefited greatly from the new post-war order and the early opportunities of globalization.

Part of South Korea’s success came from not having to shoulder excessive defense costs, since it benefited from the US security umbrella. Another decisive factor was its establishment of diplomatic relations with China in 1992. At that time, South Korea’s leadership showed considerable creativity in foreign policy, including its handling of the Taiwan question. This diplomatic strategy allowed South Korea to tap into China’s vast market on one side, while also drawing on advanced technology and resources from Europe and the United States. As a result, South Korea found itself in a highly advantageous position for growth.

Thanks to this, South Korea's economy advanced rapidly, becoming one of the few Asian countries to join the ranks of developed nations and a member of the OECD. Its path of development is often cited as a model success story in Asia.

Of course, South Korea now faces a number of challenges: demographic aging, geopolitical tensions, the North-South conflict, and the delicate task of managing relations with China. These factors place the country at a critical crossroads, where it must carefully balance ties with its neighbors, particularly economic and diplomatic relations with its largest trading partner.

Culturally and historically, South Korea belongs to the Confucian cultural sphere and is part of the East Asian civilization, sharing deep-rooted ties and similarities with China. Looking ahead, South Korea's future development will remain closely linked to China's vast market and stable relations. This connection will be vital both for South Korea's economic prospects and for maintaining regional stability.

Chosun Ilbo: Since 2018, as US-China relations have grown more strained, how has South Korea's international position and role changed from China's perspective?

Henry Huiyao Wang: The situation can be described this way: from South Korea's standpoint, the deployment of the THAAD system some years ago triggered deep dissatisfaction and protests from China. South Korea must carefully navigate the geopolitical realities of dealing with major powers. On the one hand, it hosts US troops on its soil; on the other, it faces the nuclear threat from North Korea. Against this backdrop, maintaining a stable and constructive relationship with China is of critical importance. In a sense, South Korea would be well served by pursuing a balanced and pragmatic foreign policy.

In recent years, China-South Korea relations have gone through ups and downs. A relatively positive example came when President Yoon Suk Yeol declined to meet with Nancy Pelosi during her controversial visit to Taiwan. Since taking office, President Lee Jae Myun has also reiterated the importance of pursuing "pragmatic diplomacy" toward China, which is another encouraging sign. South Korea needs to remain clear-eyed about where its largest market lies: China is its biggest trading partner. For the sake of national interest and economic growth, preserving stable ties with China is indispensable.

On the North Korean issue, South Korea should take further steps to promote reconciliation on the peninsula. The new administration has floated some fresh policy ideas, which are positive signals. First and foremost, all provocative military actions should be halted, while efforts should be made to build a more durable peace mechanism. Since the Korean Peninsula is still technically in a state of armistice, it would be worth considering a formal peace agreement under the original Panmunjom framework, signed by the United States, China, South Korea, and North Korea, to ensure denuclearization and advance peace.

Overall, South Korea plays a pivotal role in maintaining regional stability, promoting North-South reconciliation, and managing China-US relations. With an active and steady diplomatic approach, the country can reduce risks and secure both its development and the security of the region.

Chosun Ilbo: What role do you think China can play in advancing peace on the Korean Peninsula?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I think China can play a very important role. As a neighbor of North Korea, China accounts for the majority of Pyongyang's trade and economic exchanges. Historically, too, ties run deep—during the Korean War, China sent hundreds of thousands of volunteers to support North Korea. This legacy underpins the enduring traditional bond between the two sides.

Today, South Korea is also economically intertwined with China, and Beijing has significant leverage when it comes to mediation. Recent examples show China's effectiveness in conflict resolution: brokering reconciliation between Iran and Saudi Arabia, easing tensions between Cambodia and Thailand, and helping mend relations between Pakistan and Afghanistan. These precedents demonstrate that China is fully capable of facilitating peace talks within a Panmunjom-based four-party framework, opening the way toward a new peace arrangement for the Korean Peninsula.

This is especially relevant now, as the US president has expressed interest in advancing regional peace and meeting both South Korean and North Korean leaders. China has successfully chaired the Six-Party Talks in the past and helped achieve UN Security Council resolutions. It is entirely feasible for China to help relaunch four-party negotiations under UN auspices to push the peace process forward.

Chosun Ilbo: Why reduce the Six-Party Talks to a Four-Party framework?

Henry Huiyao Wang: By “four parties,” I mean the original signatories of the Panmunjom Agreement. That framework is still valid today and could be used again.

Chosun Ilbo: Recently, South Korea's new foreign minister, Cho Hyun, said in an interview with the Washington Post that China is “becoming somewhat problematic with its neighbors.” What is your view of this remark? And given that it came after the new South Korean administration took office, what does such a sensitive statement suggest for China?

Henry Huiyao Wang: That remark reflects a clear misunderstanding and a lack of nuanced knowledge about China. In fact, it contains many misreadings and misjudgments. China today is one of the most important forces for peace globally. Whether in mediating regional conflicts or in other areas, China has consistently acted as a stabilizing “ballast stone.” It has become an essential anchor for global and regional economic stability, while also maintaining close ties with other nations and serving as many countries' largest trading partner.

As for the issues Cho Hyun alluded to, these likely involve the South China Sea or Taiwan Strait. On such matters, China has its own positions and reasons rooted in defending national sovereignty. To conflate these disputes with China's overall neighborhood policy is inaccurate. From a South Korean perspective, such statements lack responsibility and do little to support the stability or healthy development of China-South Korea relations.

Chosun Ilbo: Understood. In terms of economics, technology, and security, what do you see as China's strategic priorities toward South Korea? Not only economically, but also from a security perspective.

Henry Huiyao Wang: China's foreign policy has been consistent and coherent. As early as the Bandung Conference several decades ago, China articulated the Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence, and that concept remains a cornerstone of Chinese diplomacy today. As a close neighbor with deep historical ties and cultural affinities, including what might be called a shared "chopstick culture," South Korea has a natural foundation for mutual trust and cooperation with China.

South Korea's strengths in high technology, particularly semiconductors and advanced manufacturing, complement China's vast market. Healthy China-South Korea relations not only ensure steady long-term economic growth for both sides but also foster people-to-people exchange and contribute to peace and stability on the Korean Peninsula. Good China-South Korea relations also create conditions for further progress in inter-Korean relations, which could bring more lasting peace to the peninsula.

From a geopolitical perspective, China is the peninsula's largest neighbor and principal economic partner. South Korea, therefore, needs to manage relations with China with particular care. At the same time, because US troops remain stationed in South Korea, the country must maintain strategic neutrality, focusing on developing economic and social exchanges rather than aligning too closely with any specific military bloc. During the Biden administration, South Korea joined the so-called Camp David Summit with the United States and Japan, forming a small-circle security alliance. Such moves are unfavorable for China-South Korea relations and deserve attention.

Overall, as China's influence, capacity for economic cooperation, and soft power continue to expand, South Korea, while keeping normal relations with other major powers, should attach great importance to friendly cooperation with China. This is a matter that requires special attention and careful handling.

Chosun Ilbo: In the past, China-South Korea economic cooperation was particularly close, largely because of market complementarities. But now, in areas like science and technology, especially high-tech industries, the two countries are also competitors, and in some sectors, China is even seen as having pulled ahead. In this context, how can South Korea continue to benefit from cooperation with China and maintain a mutually beneficial relationship?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I think there is still a great deal South Korea can do to strengthen cooperation with China. First, South Korea has historically had a very large number of students studying in China—at its peak, tens of thousands, more than from any other country. This is an area where the two sides can deepen cooperation. Korean and Chinese companies could also work together to expand into third-country markets, including Latin America, Africa, ASEAN, Central Asia, and the Middle East. South Korea's capabilities in these regions can complement China's outreach.

Second, South Korea's tourism industry remains very strong, and it is one of the most popular destinations for Chinese tourists. The inflow of Chinese visitors brings significant services trade revenue, which carries important economic value for South Korea.

Third, maintaining positive relations with China will also bring political and security dividends for South Korea. In the past, South Korea benefited economically from cooperation with China; in the future, it will also benefit from China's role in ensuring peace and stability on the Korean Peninsula, helping to prevent potential conflict. China's coordinating role in inter-Korean peace matters is crucial to South Korea's security.

From a historical perspective, China was a signatory to the Panmunjom Armistice Agreement, and good relations with China have never been to South Korea's detriment. On the contrary, they have delivered long-term benefits. South Korea should not measure cooperation with China purely in terms of trade volumes, but rather in a comprehensive way, including cultural exchange, student programs, and joint ventures in third-country markets. In regional trade cooperation, South Korea has expressed interest in joining the CPTPP, while China has also shown willingness. Under the RCEP framework, both countries can further advance the building of a China-Japan-South Korea free trade zone, where South Korea could play a significant role.

In addition, South Korea has already demonstrated leadership in promoting regional cooperation through the China-Japan-South Korea trilateral mechanism. It can continue to play that positive role in the future. The scope for cooperation is wide-ranging: maintaining good relations with China will not only generate economic benefits but will also support political stability, security, and regional peace. This is an effort worth pursuing further.

Chosun Ilbo: You just mentioned the North Korea issue and the Six-Party Talks. After the signing of the September 19 Joint Statement, there was a more concrete articulation of the goal of denuclearization of North Korea, as well as commitments to dismantle nuclear facilities. However, those promises were never carried out, and the process eventually stalled. At this point, North Korea has effectively become a de facto nuclear-armed state. In your view, what were the main problems with the Six-Party Talks model?

Henry Huiyao Wang: The Six-Party Talks were actually quite successful at the time. They laid the groundwork for subsequent UN Security Council resolutions, as all parties agreed that the Korean Peninsula should remain denuclearized. Both China and the United States voted in favor, which directly led to sanctions on North Korea. The process also paved the way for later high-level meetings between US President Donald Trump and the North Korean leader. In this sense, the Six-Party Talks played a critical role in building consensus.

The problem was that the talks did not continue. Because of regional tensions, changes of administration in the United States, and political shifts in South Korea and Japan, there was no continuous mechanism to ensure implementation. China, however, maintained a consistent and stable policy throughout.

Given that the current US president is actively promoting regional peace, China could work with the United States to push forward reconciliation and eventual reunification on the Korean Peninsula. With South Korea's new president, Lee Jae-myung, also signaling a willingness to adopt a more proactive diplomacy, favorable conditions exist for peace. China could serve as a key player in fostering reconciliation.

It is therefore entirely possible to build on the original four-party Panmunjom framework, revisit the armistice, and transform it into a peace treaty, thereby launching a new peace process on the Korean Peninsula, with China, the United States, and the two Koreas all participating. If such a process were to succeed, the benefits for South Korea would be considerable: the peninsula could emerge as a unified market of 70 to 80 million people, generating economic, political, and social dividends. Without question, this would represent a major strategic opportunity for South Korea's future development.

Part III Commemorating the Victory in World War II and Shared Historical Memory

Chosun Ilbo: In China, commemorations take place on September 3. South Korea is among the very few countries that mark this anniversary alongside China. Do you believe it would be significant for China if South Korea's new president, Lee Jae-myung, were to attend this year's commemoration?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I think it would be very important, and China would welcome such participation. Ten years ago, former South Korean President Park Geun-hye also came to Beijing for China's military parade. The symbolism is strong, as China and South Korea share the historical memory of the 80th anniversary of victory in the anti-fascist war. These commemorations attract many world leaders, and as a close neighbor, South Korea has every reason to take part.

Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi is also expected to attend the Shanghai Cooperation Organization summit on the eve of the parade in China, even if he does not take part in the parade itself. His participation underscores an effort to demonstrate strategic autonomy from the United States and pursue greater independence in foreign policy.

For President Lee Jae-myung, personally attending China's commemoration would not only underscore South Korea's renewed reflection on Japan's wartime history but also help advance peace in Asia, particularly in Northeast Asia, by fostering a more unified regional voice. In my view, the South Korean president must participate, and such a gesture would certainly be warmly received by China.

Chosun Ilbo: The concern, however, is that leaders such as President Lee Jae-myung may weigh historical experience. A decade ago, after President Park Geun-hye visited China, the United States reacted to Seoul's growing closeness with Beijing, triggering a series of follow-up events. This time, when deciding whether to participate, President Lee may also take into account Washington's attitude and the potential consequences. In this context, South Korea's choice and situation appear quite complex. How do you assess this situation?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I don't think it should be a major concern. Today, every country should exercise a certain degree of strategic autonomy. India, for example, maintains good relations with the United States but still chooses to visit China. By the same logic, South Korea, as China's close neighbor, has every reason to take part in Chinese activities or visit China. Such exchanges represent reconciliation and interaction between nations. They should not be confined to visits to Washington alone, nor to Beijing alone. As a middle power, South Korea ought to maintain its own independence.

Moreover, these events also reflect history and shared memory. During World War II, China and South Korea fought together against Japanese fascism. That is a shared historical legacy, and participation in such commemorations carries significant meaning.

I would add that this has little to do with whether Trump might be petty-minded. Compared with Biden, Trump places greater emphasis on economic cooperation rather than geopolitical alliances. His reassessment of arrangements such as the AUKUS shows that he is less inclined to push multinational alliances than his predecessor, focusing instead on economic gains. If Trump returns to an economy-centered policy track, it may not necessarily be a bad thing for China. This would mean countries could engage in rational, healthy economic competition and cooperation, learning from each other's management and development experiences, and contributing more to the world. From this perspective, South Korea stands to gain significantly by maintaining a balanced approach to both China and the United States.

Chosun Ilbo: You mentioned a process of "reconciliation and cooperation." Could you elaborate?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Yes. What I mean is that South Korea needs to be more engaged in the process of managing US-China relations. The commemoration of the victory in the War of Resistance against Japan is also an important moment for reflection—"remembering the past to guide the future." China and South Korea share many experiences and understandings here, with plenty of common ground. These can be harnessed to better manage both China-South Korea relations and, at the same time, China-US relations. South Korea can act as a bridge, a go-between, and help improve and advance relations between Beijing and Washington. That role is entirely possible.

Chosun Ilbo: You just mentioned that South Korea may play a role in improving US-China relations. But what signal would it send to China if Seoul were instead to draw closer to Japan?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I believe China, South Korea, and Japan should all move closer together and deepen cooperation. After all, the three countries are in Northeast Asia, part of the East Asian cultural sphere, sharing a "chopstick culture" as well as deep roots in Buddhism, literature, language, and historical tradition. The three should forge tighter bonds and eventually extend regional cooperation to include ASEAN, perhaps even exploring the creation of an Asian currency and forming an "Asian

Union” akin to the EU. Within this framework, China, Japan, and South Korea could take on a leadership role, with ASEAN countries also participating.

This would be a highly promising direction. Asia's weight in the global economy is set to keep rising—today Asia accounts for about 50 percent of global GDP, and this may reach 60 to 70 percent in the future. Against that backdrop, major Asian economies such as China, Japan, South Korea, and eventually India can work together. At this stage, efforts should focus on building a Northeast Asia Free Trade Zone and integrating a Northeast Asia-Southeast Asia economic bloc, gradually shaping an open and free regional trade and cooperation mechanism—what could be called an “Asian Union.”

Such an approach would foster good-neighborliness and strengthen regional cooperation, which is vital for future peace and development. It is also noteworthy that in recent decades, Asia has seen few large-scale wars (apart from smaller clashes such as the recent Cambodia-Thailand dispute), giving both a historical and practical foundation for integration. China, Japan, and South Korea should be thinking seriously about how to better collaborate within the region and jointly lead the next stage of Asia's economic integration.

Chosun Ilbo: You just mentioned the idea of an Asian currency. Are you referring to something like a unified monetary system similar to the euro, or do you have other designs in mind?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Yes, why not consider an Asian currency? I believe this is entirely possible. If Asia's economy develops to a sufficient level, the region could certainly have its own currency—a unified Asian monetary system. Both in theory and in practice, such a system is feasible.

Chosun Ilbo: Looking ahead, in the context of China-South Korea cooperation, what would you identify as China's non-negotiable red lines in foreign policy? Could you give some concrete examples?

Henry Huiyao Wang: There are several points worth noting. First and foremost is the Taiwan question. Taiwan is an inseparable part of China, a fact that is widely recognized. Second, South Korea should avoid adopting a one-sided diplomatic strategy. Given its geographic position, deep economic interdependence with China, and its unique relationship with North Korea, Seoul cannot afford to take a unilateral stance—it must strike a balance among all parties.

Maintaining this balance is crucial, whether in managing relations with the United States, with China, or with Japan. South Korea should avoid being locked into a trilateral US-Japan-Korea military alliance or engaging in overly one-sided joint military exercises.

It is also important to remember that China remains South Korea's largest trading partner. Bilateral relations should be further deepened. Recently, South Korea's decision to grant temporary visa-free entry to Chinese tour groups was a positive step. Looking forward, Seoul could also consider easing visa restrictions for individual Chinese travelers and expanding opportunities for Chinese students to study in South

Korea, while also encouraging more South Koreans to study in China. Such measures would foster greater practical cooperation between the two countries.

In summary, the fundamental red line in diplomacy is not to infringe on each other's core interests. That, I believe, is the most important principle.

Part IV Leadership Dynamics and Future Outlook

Chosun Ilbo: Understood. You also mentioned that the APEC Leaders' Informal Dialogue will soon be held in Gyeongju, South Korea. This will be an important opportunity for Chinese and Korean leaders to meet. What issues do you expect the two sides to focus on in such a face-to-face meeting? What impact might these discussions have on the future of China-South Korea relations?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I think this is indeed very significant. With South Korea hosting this year's APEC Leaders' Informal Dialogue, the event itself provides an excellent opportunity. Looking back at last year's APEC meeting in Lima, there was even a US-China leaders' summit. This year, Seoul may play an important role in facilitating another such meeting. As host, the South Korean leader's engagement with the Chinese leader would also highlight Korea's diplomatic strengths—its neutrality, fairness, and ability to maintain balance—and could help foster more constructive regional relations.

Historically, APEC has achieved remarkable results, advancing many forms of cooperation among member economies. As the forum has grown into a central platform for Asia-Pacific economic cooperation, its leaders' meetings remain highly influential in driving integration. Notably, APEC includes China, Chinese Taipei, and Hong Kong, which demonstrates its unique value in bridging differences and fostering regional cooperation. I would even suggest that South Korea could consider inviting North Korea to participate, using APEC as a breakthrough to promote reconciliation on the peninsula, and potentially convening a four-party meeting involving China, the US, South Korea, and North Korea on the sidelines.

On the economic agenda, advancing Asia-Pacific integration remains a key objective. While frameworks such as RCEP and CPTPP are already in place, APEC proposed the idea of a Free Trade Area of the Asia-Pacific (FTAAP) many years ago. In my view, building a comprehensive pan-Asia-Pacific free trade area should be a central topic at this year's APEC meeting. Such an initiative would not only help counter the challenges of unilateralism and protectionism but also serve the shared interests of South Korea, China, Japan, the EU, and others in pursuing deeper trade integration. Upholding Asia-Pacific integration and advancing free trade will, I believe, be defining themes of this year's APEC discussions.

Chosun Ilbo: South Korea has long expressed some concerns about Asian economic integration, mainly regarding the influence of Chinese standards. As a major power in Asia, China carries significant weight in standard-setting, and its supply chains dominate many sectors—factors that naturally draw South Korea's attention. In addition, Seoul's security and geopolitical ties with Western countries have, to some extent, constrained its participation in regional integration. Taken together, these factors shape Korea's hesitation toward deeper integration in Asia. Given these concerns,

what persuasive arguments should China put forward to help South Korea better understand and feel willing to participate in this integration process?

Henry Huiyao Wang: If South Korea wishes to demonstrate leadership, APEC is an excellent opportunity, since the role of host comes only once in many years. In this regard, I don't think South Korea needs to be overly worried. The United States has created many globally accepted standards; Europe has also set important international standards. Now, with China's development, new standards have naturally emerged. For instance, in green energy, clean energy vehicles, solar power, and photovoltaics, China has introduced new benchmarks, and in the future, it may also set standards in fields such as 5G and 6G. As long as these standards are open and globally friendly, they can be adopted. Standards should not be rejected simply because they originate in China, nor should they be divided along ideological lines. This is precisely the direction that should be further encouraged.

At the same time, my emphasis on the Free Trade Area of the Asia-Pacific stems from the fact that its creation would necessarily be consensus-driven. The process would involve the United States, Japan, South Korea, China, and others—no single country could dominate. Through negotiation, it is possible to establish new standards that all sides can accept, thereby advancing Asia-Pacific integration. There are already precedents for this. RCEP, for instance, was concluded after many years of negotiations and includes ASEAN, China, Japan, Korea, Australia, and New Zealand. There is also CPTPP, a higher-standard agreement covering investment and other areas, which the EU, China, and Korea could also join in the future to drive regional cooperation.

From this perspective, the APEC summit offers South Korea an excellent platform to showcase its ability to shape the agenda and exercise summit leadership. This is a highly valuable opportunity.

Chosun Ilbo: On a related note, if China's top leader were to visit Korea during this summit, it would be the first visit in 11 years. For South Korea, such a visit would carry enormous significance and is already generating high expectations. Beyond the topics related to international multilateral organizations and mechanisms that you just mentioned, what other issues do you think the two leaders might discuss during a bilateral meeting? And what major impact could these discussions have on the future of China-South Korea relations, given that this would be a direct leader-to-leader exchange?

Henry Huiyao Wang: The significance of such a visit cannot be overstated. As you mentioned, it could be the first visit by China's top leader to Korea in more than a decade—that is one important aspect. Another is that South Korea has just gone through a political transition and now has a pragmatic new president. This creates a clear need for a new narrative in China-South Korea relations.

At present, many countries are improving their relations with China. Leaders from India and various European states have recently visited, as have those from Latin America, ASEAN, and neighboring countries such as Vietnam. Against this backdrop, China and South Korea need to construct a new narrative: as close neighbors

with deep historical ties and long-standing cultural traditions, they share the heritage of East Asian civilization, are both part of the Confucian cultural sphere, and even reflect common traits such as the “chopstick culture.” A leaders’ summit provides a valuable opportunity to dispel mutual suspicion, rebuild trust, and strengthen confidence in the bilateral relationship.

For example, the release of a photo of the two leaders shaking hands, or the issuance of a new joint communiqué, could reaffirm both sides’ positions, advancing denuclearization on the Korean Peninsula and promoting regional peace. China can play an active role in mediation and dialogue. At the same time, in terms of economic cooperation, China and South Korea could further strengthen cooperation on issues such as the CPTPP and broader Asia-Pacific economic integration.

China and South Korea could also expand people-to-people and cultural exchanges in the context of third-party cooperation. Korean dramas, for instance, once enjoyed immense popularity in China, and this kind of cultural resonance could be reactivated and elevated to new heights. A high-level summit provides an opportunity to realize these goals, which could generate tangible and positive outcomes.

Chosun Ilbo: My second-to-last question is about the book *The Clash of Civilizations*. In it, the author identifies China as the core of the Sinic world. Do you think the present era validates some of the book’s arguments? For example, could US-China competition be understood as a structural struggle between Western civilization and the Sinosphere? From this perspective, which parts do you agree with, and which do you reject?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I believe that while differences between civilizations certainly exist, they do not inevitably lead to war. Chinese civilization is an extensive and profound tradition with an unbroken history of more than 5,000 years. It originated in the agrarian societies of the Yangtze and Yellow River basins, where stability, careful cultivation, and orderly management of land shaped values emphasizing order and harmony.

This cultural foundation nurtured a philosophy of peace, expressed in the idea that “harmony is most precious.” Historically, when Admiral Zheng He sailed to the Western Seas—long before Columbus reached the Americas—he did not pursue colonial expansion. China’s rise has never implied a quest for hegemony; the Western notion that “a strong nation must dominate” does not apply to the Chinese cultural tradition. Today, China promotes economic globalization and initiatives such as the Belt and Road Initiative, encouraging mutual interdependence. The concept of “you are in me, and I am in you” makes a full-scale China-US trade confrontation unworkable, reflecting instead the value of cooperation and inclusiveness among civilizations.

From this perspective, the breadth of East Asian and Chinese civilization should be celebrated, while also recognizing the strengths and values of Western civilization. The world has entered an era of peaceful competition, where differences among civilizations are no longer addressed through conquest or force. In the context of nuclear

deterrence, the destructiveness of war makes direct conflict almost unthinkable, so competition must be constructive, primarily in economic and cultural spheres.

China has demonstrated clear strengths in this competition. At the same time, the broader East Asian region, including South Korea, Japan, and Southeast Asian countries, also form part of the East Asian civilizational sphere. The positive elements of this shared heritage should be leveraged to prevent conflict and war and to foster regional cooperation. At the heart of Chinese civilization lies a culture of peace, and it is on this foundation that the present era should be understood and peaceful competition between civilizations and nations achieved.

From a military perspective, even China's parade reflects this principle. They are not intended merely as displays of force but as demonstrations of self-defense and resilience, signaling that China does not seek conflict but is prepared to respond to potential threats. This underpins the sustainability of peaceful competition. In the current era, competition should be understood as peaceful competition, civilizational competition, and economic competition. East Asian countries should work together for shared development.

Chosun Ilbo: Finally, do you have a message for South Korea about its next 80 years, or is there anything you would like to add that we haven't yet discussed? Please feel free to share your thoughts.

Henry Huiyao Wang: Yes. I believe South Korea is a highly meaningful example for Asia. Since World War II, it has been one of the fastest-growing countries in the region and among the few to enter the ranks of developed nations, second only to Japan. It also possesses a rich culture and a long history. Historically, relations between China and South Korea have been generally positive, and as close neighbors, the two should continue to deepen cultural exchange and cooperation.

At present, South Korea faces the critical challenge of peace on the Korean Peninsula. Looking ahead, it should work more closely with both China and the United States to resolve the North Korean nuclear issue and achieve peace and eventual reunification on the peninsula. I see this as the most important direction for China-South Korea cooperation and the most vital task for South Korea's future. My message to South Korea is therefore this: I hope that four-party talks can proceed smoothly, laying the groundwork for a sustainable peace framework on the Korean Peninsula and ensuring long-term regional stability and prosperity.

Chosun Ilbo: Thank you! This interview lasted exactly one hour. I truly appreciate your time and cooperation.

Henry Huiyao Wang: Thank you very much.

Chosun Ilbo: I look forward to seeing you again at the next event.

Modi's China Visit and Putin's Attendance Highlight SCO'S Role²

CCG President Henry Huiyao Wang tells Hong Kong's Television Broadcasts Limited that China, India, and others could take the lead in responses to trade wars, Ukraine, and the Middle East.

The 25th Meeting of the Council of Heads of State of the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) was held in Tianjin from August 31 to September 1, 2025. This is the fifth time China has hosted the SCO summit and the largest since the organization's founding.

Before the summit, on August 19, Henry Huiyao Wang gave an interview to Hong Kong's Television Broadcasts Limited (TVB), one of the world's largest commercial producers of Chinese language programmes. He analyzed the key issues likely to be discussed at the upcoming Tianjin summit, including global security, trade frictions, economic cooperation, and major regional relations.

SCO Tianjin Summit: Get Ready for Big Moments

TVB: What do you consider the key areas that deserve particular attention at this year's SCO summit?

Henry Huiyao Wang: The SCO has become an important driver in promoting regional and global harmony. In the face of global trade frictions, the question has arisen of how to respond effectively to issues such as the Russia-Ukraine war, the Israel-Palestine conflict, and persistent instability worldwide, especially the recent escalation in the Middle East. The SCO should articulate its views and positions, which is why the statements and positions to be presented at this year's summit on these major international issues warrant particular attention.

Meanwhile, the attendance of both Chinese and Indian leaders at the SCO summit has drawn significant attention, particularly as Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi is visiting China for the first time in seven years. This development alone underscores the importance of the event. Additionally, given the ongoing tensions between India and Pakistan, the simultaneous presence of both countries' leaders on this international platform is also worthy of close observation.

This summit will also witness the participation of leaders from an even greater number of countries. It is particularly noteworthy that a significant portion of these leaders will remain in China after the meeting to attend a military parade on September 3rd commemorating the 80th anniversary of the victory in the Chinese People's War of Resistance Against Japanese Aggression and the World Anti-Fascist War. This series of events highlights the importance of the SCO and its increasingly prominent role in a multipolar world.

TVB: Given that economic and trade wars, as you've mentioned, are likely to be major topics of discussion at this summit, what potential consensus do you believe

² This is a translation based on a transcript of the original Chinese interview, which is available on CCG's official WeChat blog.

participating countries will reach on this issue, especially against the backdrop of the US employing tariff threats and hegemonic practices?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Since taking office, Trump has abandoned multilateralism in favor of unilateral measures. He has demanded tariff revisions from more than 100 countries and imposed substantial increases on many of them. Tariffs have risen sharply on imports from the European Union, Japan, South Korea, and several ASEAN member states. Relations with China remain in a state of repeated suspension, with both sides again postponing the imposition of 24% tariffs for another 90 days. After the recent talks in Stockholm, this uncertainty continues.

I believe the future course will depend on how different nations choose to respond. China's approach has been to refuse intimidation, to stand firm in resistance, and to counter US unilateral sanctions with corresponding measures. This approach has, to some extent, set an important example for the world. In this regard, if countries of the Global South, such as Brazil, South Africa, and India (which itself remains in a stalemate with the United States), can draw lessons from China's experience, it could significantly strengthen collective efforts to resist unilateralism and trade coercion.

China has played a leading role in responding to the tariff war. At the same time, the future world requires greater efforts to uphold multilateralism. Although the World Trade Organization (WTO) has not yet been able to fully perform its functions, China can play an even more significant role in promoting regional multilateralism, such as in the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP).

SCO's Success Code: Unity Despite Divergence

TVB: Focusing on the SCO as a mechanism, in which areas must it strengthen unity to address challenges from the US?

Henry Huiyao Wang: First and foremost, the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) is a highly significant platform. Unlike US-led organizations such as NATO, the SCO is marked by strong inclusiveness, bringing together members such as India, Central Asian states, Russia, and China. Although these countries differ in their social systems and models of governance, the SCO does not create divisions along ideological lines. This contrasts sharply with the Group of Seven (G7), which frequently frames its agenda around the narrative of "democracy versus autocracy." By comparison, the SCO emphasizes security, shared prosperity, and common development, with economic globalization at the core of its mission. The greatest strength of this coalition of states lies in its vast economic potential and broad prospects for future growth.

The SCO is not just an economic community but rather a new platform for multilateral collaboration. As the organization continues to evolve, its member states are actively exploring innovative models of cooperation. Last year's "Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Plus" meeting in Astana, Kazakhstan, for instance, yielded many constructive proposals aimed at enhancing regional cooperation. These efforts have collectively charted a clear course for the organization's future development.

Therefore, I believe the SCO can progressively evolve into a more multilateral platform for regional economic and trade cooperation. This would not only help

deepen economic ties among member states but also provide an effective means to collectively address the unilateralism and trade protectionism currently championed by the United States. From this perspective, the SCO carries a significant mission in its future development.

TVB: However, if, as you just mentioned, SCO member states have differences in ideology and systems, wouldn't reaching consensus on areas like trade and tariffs face significant difficulties? Is there a possibility that each country might pursue its own agenda, leading to fragmented positions?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Indeed, such a scenario cannot be ruled out. Despite considerable differences in national values, the key advantage is that countries generally follow the principle of seeking benefit and avoiding conflict, and all are in pursuit of common interests. In this sense, whether between China and Russia, China and India, China and the Central Asian states, or even China and Iran, there are substantial shared interests. By aligning these interests, member states can forge closer bonds.

In fact, the WTO is an international organization that encompasses countries with diverse ideologies, and the SCO possesses similar potential. In the future, the SCO could potentially not only expand its membership but also enhance its economic appeal by promoting the establishment of development zones and economic cooperation areas among member states. Meanwhile, as Chinese companies accelerate their "going global" strategies, they have been widely welcomed across SCO nations, laying a solid foundation for deeper collaboration within the organization.

Even with ideological differences, economic integration can help reduce mutual distrust and thereby enhance bilateral and multilateral cooperation. This approach, in turn, helps bridge divides and strengthen mutual trust. For example, the economies of China and India are highly complementary. While India rivals China in terms of population, it still has vast development potential in areas such as infrastructure, rural development, the digital economy, environmental protection, and green energy, all fields where China possesses significant advantages. There is also substantial potential for collaboration in sectors like real estate.

If the SCO can reach consensus in these areas, it will not only help stabilize relations among member states but also deepen China's cooperation with member countries. More importantly, it could align with the Belt and Road Initiative, thereby playing a critically important role.

TVB: Is it possible for the member states to unite and form an alliance to counterbalance the United States?

Henry Huiyao Wang: At present, it appears that countries such as India and some other member states do not necessarily endorse the idea of uniting the SCO into an anti-US alliance. In fact, China has never advanced such a proposal. China has consistently stressed that the SCO should adhere to principles of "non-alignment, non-confrontation with other countries, and openness." This has been the guiding philosophy of the organization since its founding and throughout its development.

However, SCO member states do share common security needs. In areas such as counterterrorism, combating extremism, addressing cyberattacks, and preventing

threats to space security, the SCO is well-positioned to facilitate connectivity and the sharing of resources and intelligence. When necessary, if a member state faces external threats, the organization can also respond through information exchange, mutual support, and even joint actions, provided that such efforts align with just and legitimate causes.

From this perspective, the SCO already possesses a solid foundation and institutional capacity for cooperation. It has the potential to evolve not only into a more multilateral platform for economic collaboration but also into a framework for security cooperation and may even expand into a comprehensive multilateral mechanism in the future. In my view, the SCO is not necessarily oriented against any third party or designed to confront any specific nation. Instead, it is more likely to grow into a significant platform guided by principles of self-defense and win-win cooperation.

TVB: Member states can deepen their cooperation in finance and trade.

Henry Huiyao Wang: Absolutely, I believe this is entirely feasible. For instance, various new financial experiments could be explored, including the possibility of using currencies other than the US dollar for trade settlements among SCO member states. Additionally, the SCO could consider establishing its own economic development zones. In this process, the role of a “leading engine” is crucial. As the largest economy within the organization, China is undoubtedly positioned to take on significant responsibility in guiding these efforts.

This encapsulates the significance of the SCO as I understand it. It should aim to expand the “pie” through economic cooperation and, by closely interlinking interests, promote not only a shared future but also a community of common interests among member states. On this foundation, it is possible to gradually bridge differences in ideology and values, thereby safeguarding common security, development, and prosperity.

Putin's and Modi's Attendance Highlight China's Key Role

TVB: A major highlight this year is President Putin's attendance at the SCO summit. In your opinion, how can China and Russia further enhance their cooperation following this meeting?

Henry Huiyao Wang: The Russia-Ukraine war has now dragged on for three and a half years, and President Putin has come to realize this is a protracted war of attrition. Russia is not only confronting Ukraine but is effectively locked in a standoff with the whole of Europe and even the Western world. Russia is experiencing growing fatigue and faces increasing difficulty in sustaining the confrontation indefinitely.

In a sense, it is the maintenance of normal trade relations by SCO countries such as China and India with Russia that has prevented the Russian economy from collapsing swiftly under Western sanctions. I believe Putin must be profoundly grateful for this.

Recently, I published an article in *Foreign Policy* noting that the US president currently seeks to promote peace talks and mediation regarding the Ukraine issue. He has already invited Zelenskyy and several European Union leaders to meet with

Putin in Washington. If negotiations indeed move forward and lead to an agreement, the discussion would likely extend to the deployment of peacekeeping forces after a potential border freeze. Clearly, these peacekeeping forces cannot be entirely provided by the EU. The United States has also explicitly stated that it will not deploy troops, meaning the mission would require a joint force comprising both EU and non-EU contributors. The question then arises: where would these non-EU forces come from? They would most likely be drawn from SCO member states, such as China, India, and Pakistan.

When Putin eventually enters genuine negotiations with the US president, the Ukrainian President, and European Union leaders, a critical question will emerge: While Ukraine would be backed by numerous EU countries in potential peacekeeping operations, who would stand behind Russia? After three and a half years of war, Putin is well aware that the root of this war lies in NATO's eastward expansion. Hence, he is unlikely to accept the redeployment of NATO or European troops near the contested border. A more realistic solution would be a United Nations-led peacekeeping force, composed of troops from both EU and SCO member states, working together to maintain a new ceasefire line between Russia and Ukraine. In my view, this may be exactly what Putin will urgently need moving forward.

TVB: Two weeks after the recent US-Russia summit, the leaders of China and Russia are also scheduled to meet. Do you believe China can play a greater role in facilitating a ceasefire between Russia and Ukraine?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I believe China is indeed well-positioned to play a greater role at this stage. As a permanent member of the UN Security Council, China carries no historical burden in this conflict. At the same time, it is a major trading partner of both Russia and Ukraine and maintains constructive relations with each. This places China in a particularly important position, especially with regard to offering potential security guarantees.

Even if Russia and Ukraine eventually reach an agreement, the question of who can provide credible guarantees remains central. While the United States, the European Union, or NATO could theoretically offer such guarantees, it is uncertain whether Putin would fully accept or trust them. However, if the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, particularly China and India, were to play a role in the guarantee mechanism, it would carry substantial weight and would be far more likely to be accepted by Putin.

Therefore, I am convinced that SCO countries, particularly China and India, can play crucial roles in ultimately achieving a peaceful resolution to the Russia-Ukraine war.

TVB: The outcome could potentially be more significant than what a standalone meeting between Trump and Putin might achieve.

Henry Huiyao Wang: That is entirely possible. In my article for *Foreign Policy*, I proposed the idea of convening a seven-party talk, which could be held in Beijing. The five permanent members of the UN Security Council, along with the European Union, Ukraine, and even India, could even form an eight-party dialogue hosted in

China. This initiative would aim to promote a resolution to the Russia-Ukraine war while also addressing future reconstruction efforts in Ukraine.

China possesses significant advantages in global infrastructure development and could provide loans to Ukraine through the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB). While the United States has already signed major mineral agreements with Ukraine, I believe China's participation in promoting Ukraine's reconstruction would hold highly positive implications for Sino-American cooperation in jointly advancing a resolution to the Ukraine issue.

TVB: Another focal point of this summit is Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who is visiting China after a seven-year interval. What do you believe this signifies?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I believe the international situation has changed significantly. India, a nation with deep pride in its history and culture, has consistently upheld a policy of "strategic autonomy." Recently, however, the United States imposed restrictions on India, levying additional tariffs on Indian exports on the grounds that it had "directly or indirectly imported Russian oil." Such measures are, in essence, unfair, as normal trade should not be subject to sanctions. This episode serves as a clear warning to India: even in the context of friendly relations with the United States, countries must still strive to maintain balance in their dealings with major powers.

As a close neighbor and the world's second-largest economy, maintaining positive relations with China offers numerous benefits for India. At the same time, India is not a country that places excessive emphasis on ideology. In my view, India has ample reason to advance its relationship with China. I recently attended the Indian Embassy's Independence Day reception, where the Indian Ambassador noted that in 1950, India was the first non-socialist country to establish diplomatic relations with the newly founded People's Republic of China. This year marks the 75th anniversary of diplomatic ties between India and China, which carries profound historical significance.

The combined population of China and India amounts to approximately 2.8 billion people, accounting for over one-third of the global total. Should the two countries pursue collaboration in the future, it would carry significant strategic implications, contributing to a more stable and substantive multipolar world.

TVB: Is this also because they have come to realize that the United States, the "big brother," is not entirely reliable, prompting them to seek stronger ties with China?

Henry Huiyao Wang: India has clearly adopted a pragmatic approach. There was once a perception that if China-US relations grew tense, India could maneuver between the two sides and gain certain advantages. In reality, however, the United States has continued to prioritize its own interests at critical moments, regardless of partnerships or alliances. This has led India to recognize that "a close neighbor is more valuable than a distant relative," highlighting the importance of strengthening its relationship with China.

The current timing is highly significant. Foreign Minister Wang Yi's recent visit to India has provided an opportunity for enhanced cooperation between these two major

countries. Should China and India join hands, they could play a much greater role in international affairs. Furthermore, China's strengths in market capacity, infrastructure development, green energy, digital economy, and various products, particularly new energy vehicles (NEVs), hold substantial potential in India. With NEV penetration in India standing at only around 1%, compared to over 45% in China, there is clearly vast room for collaboration.

If China and India, each with a population of 1.4 billion, can join hands and set aside their disputes, they would achieve remarkable outcomes in promoting regional and global peace.

TVB: In which areas could breakthroughs be achieved between China and India, and how can cooperation be further strengthened?

Henry Huiyao Wang: There are many areas where China and India could make breakthroughs. First, if conditions permit, the meeting of the leaders of China and India could produce a joint statement. For example, both sides could explore ways to expand bilateral trade, advance negotiations on a possible free trade agreement, or even consider India's accession to the RCEP. Another step would be to increase flights between the two countries. While services are reportedly set to resume in September, it would be desirable to see more routes opened.

Furthermore, the two countries could promote greater openness in bilateral tourism, ease visa policies, and expand opportunities for Indian students to study in China. Before the pandemic, a large number of Indian students pursued education in China, though that number has since declined. China could also grant India broader access to its educational and other competitive resources. In addition, cooperation in new energy, environmental protection, and other sectors holds considerable promise.

Moreover, China and India can collaborate more closely on the global stage, such as within the WTO, the United Nations, and other multilateral platforms. India has now become the world's fourth-largest economy and is expected to overtake Germany to rank third within the next two to three years. Combined, the economic scale of China and India would surpass that of the United States. Cooperation between the "Dragon and the Elephant" may well serve as a stabilizer, an anchor, and a ballast for the future world order. In the long run, China-India relations carry profoundly important strategic significance.

TVB: Following this event, do you believe India will move closer to China in the long run, or will it continue to prioritize its own strategic calculations?

Henry Huiyao Wang: In a sense, India is a relatively independent and "non-aligned" nation. It cannot be expected to act entirely in line with China, but it is likely to maintain a relatively neutral stance. Nor would it serve China's interests for India to lean wholly to one side in relations among major powers. That said, it would be highly beneficial if India were to sustain positive relations with China, especially through deeper bilateral cooperation.

At the same time, China can play a balancing role in the tensions between India and Pakistan. Having previously mediated between Saudi Arabia and Iran, as well as in issues involving Afghanistan and Pakistan, China is also well-positioned to

help resolve differences between Pakistan and India. In this sense, China can take on a more significant role in promoting peace, encouraging dialogue, and facilitating reconciliation. Improving and fostering India-Pakistan relations would also serve as a crucial measure for China to enhance regional security.

TVB: This summit also marks the first meeting between the leaders of India and Pakistan since the outbreak of conflict between the two countries.

Henry Huiyao Wang: Indeed, both the Indian and Pakistani leaders will visit China on this occasion, marking their first trips to the country since the outbreak of conflict between the two nations. The platform provided by China holds considerable appeal for them and may facilitate new breakthroughs. I am confident that Chinese leadership will play a greater role in mediating dialogue and promoting reconciliation between India and Pakistan, thereby advancing regional peace. Should both countries gain more support from China throughout this process, it would further improve Sino-Indian and Sino-Pakistani relations. Such progress would contribute to peace and stability in the South Asian subcontinent and generate positive ripple effects for Northeast Asia.

TVB: Another point to note is that the Iranian president will also be visiting Tianjin. In light of the recent US strikes on Iranian nuclear facilities, do you think this will prompt Iran to pursue closer cooperation with China, particularly as it looks to acquire Chinese military equipment after observing the India-Pakistan conflict?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I believe this is entirely possible. The Iranian president's visit highlights the stable and positive relationship Iran has maintained with China's leadership, as well as China's role as the largest importer of Iranian oil. Having recently faced considerable external pressure, Iran now needs more international support to uphold justice and legitimacy, whether in the United Nations, the International Atomic Energy Agency, or on issues such as the Israeli-Palestinian conflict in the Middle East. In these arenas, China is well-positioned to serve as an important voice and source of support.

Amid broader conflicts in the Middle East, the SCO also has the potential to play a constructive role. I expect Iran to benefit significantly from participating in this summit and to feel both understood and supported by China. Tehran may well come to recognize that with China's involvement, the international order can be made more secure. In my view, in a multipolar world, the SCO can play a bigger role in advancing peace, promoting development, and fostering integration. I therefore have high expectations for the upcoming SCO Tianjin summit.

Modi and Xi Jinping Will Resist Any Trump Tariff Pressure³

As top diplomats from China and India met in New Delhi ahead of the potential first visit to China made by Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi in seven years, the Center for China and Globalization (CCG) presents an interview with its president, Henry Huiyao Wang, on Republic TV, a leading English-language news channel in India. The interview, uploaded to YouTube on August 14, 2025, featured Wang in conversation with Republic TV's executive editor. Wang said India and China "should really stand up and work together to safeguard the multilateral system" and emphasized that Modi's long-overdue trip to China could "generate some positive results."

Republic TV: It's been a while since India and China sat across the table and had a genuine conversation, one that's not hostile and one that's not cold. And with the recent tariff issue vis-à-vis Trump and America, the BRICS nations have come closer than ever before.

I have someone very interesting with me on Republicworld.com today. His name is Dr. Henry Huiyao Wang. He's joining me live from Beijing. Dr. Wang is the founder and the president of the Center for China and Globalization (CCG), and he's also the former counsellor to China's State Council, so he knows a thing or two about Chinese foreign affairs and what this moment means for India, China, and the Global South. Thank you, Dr. Wang, for speaking to Republic TV.

Henry Huiyao Wang: Thank you, moderator. Absolutely. I think we are getting into a turbulent time. China often says we are seeing changes unseen in a century because the world has been greatly disrupted. This year marks 80 years of the establishment of the UN. The world we are familiar with has lifted so many billions of people out of poverty, but the system we have gotten used to is really in danger now. We see unilateralism being practiced by the United States, and President Trump actually wants to upend, or maybe reboot, the global system in a different direction.

So, I think we have a lot of challenges. India, of course, feels that, China feels the same. The EU, Japan, South Korea—you name it. A wide range of countries in the world all have this kind of disruption. But I think you're right. It's time that big countries like China, India, and the Global South, including the European Union, should really stand up and work together to safeguard the multilateral system. Even though it's not perfect, we should practice more free trade and also resist the pressure that is unilaterally put upon all of us.

I think it is high time that we get together, meet each other, compare notes, and say: let's really do things that are good for our world, and let's really make things happen. So I think this is an absolutely crucial time, a crucial moment, and we are really expecting Prime Minister Modi's visit to China, which has been overdue for a long time. But I'm very glad to see the world's two most populous countries now getting together, and I'm sure this meeting will generate some positive results.

³ This is the full transcript of the interview. Neither of the speakers has reviewed the transcript.

Republic TV: I'm going to go straight into it, Dr. Wang, to the elephant in the room. I'll be very honest with you. Here in India, we've had a war with Pakistan. It's called Operation Sindoor. It's a short war, but a lot of things have happened from the Pakistan end. There was a terrorist attack, and we know where those terrorists came from. There was an investigation.

Now, there is a feeling in India, and some of our generals also have gone on record, that China perhaps gave some support to Pakistan in this war. Now, when it comes to China and India relations, there is Pakistan, which has suddenly become a thorn, if I can say that, in relations between India and China. How do you see China tackling this Pakistan issue?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Well, China, as we all know, wants to maintain friendly and peaceful relations with all its neighbors. That's for sure. China and Pakistan have had good relations for decades, and unfortunately, we have seen some ups and downs in China-India relations. But I'm sure China wants to get along with India as well. India is a much larger and much more influential country and one of the biggest neighbors to the south of China. I don't see a reason why China can't get along with India, or India can't get along with China.

Once we have this South Asia relationship going, for example, let's resolve differences in the framework of the Shanghai Cooperation Organization or in BRICS. We are all members of those, and I'm sure China could play a mediating role between India and Pakistan, like China did with Cambodia and Thailand recently, and with Saudi Arabia and Iran a few years ago. I'm sure China has the best interest in maintaining good relations with both India and Pakistan. Things have happened in the past, there have been ups and downs, but we should all look at this with new perspectives and new solutions.

Republic TV: You've been close to the establishment in China. Do you think that it's possible? Is that the mood also in Beijing, that hopefully, when the Prime Minister of India, Narendra Modi, goes there in the next few months, there is a possible reset? Is a reset really possible vis-à-vis China and India?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I think it's totally possible. Why not? We used to enjoy good relations. We established diplomatic ties when China was established in 1949. We have 75 years of good diplomatic relations. And we share a long history between the two countries. I remember the first Chinese student who went abroad was Xuanzang, who went to India to bring Buddhism back to China. We learned a lot from India. So I see no reason.

There are so many similarities. We face the same environmental challenges, infrastructure challenges, and telecom and manufacturing opportunities. There is so much complementarity. China doesn't have to look very far—just look to the southern border with India. We could do a lot of good things together. I see this as high time that we reset. We should keep the interests of our 2.8 billion people in mind. That's a huge chunk out of the 8 billion in the world. It's so important, so powerful. If China and India can join hands—of course, not at the expense of other countries, but for our own interests—we can do much better than what we are doing now.

Republic TV: Okay, let me ask you a question. Now, I'm asking you this question as someone who heads a think tank in China. Because it's current, it's just happened. You have the Pakistani army chief, who is now a field marshal, who is in America right now. And he makes a comment in America saying that if things go very far with India, if there's a war, we can wipe out half of the world. When he makes a comment like that, when he means "half of the world," China would be affected, because you're on this half of the world with India. So, how does China look at a comment like that from a very, very senior field marshal, to say the least?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I haven't heard that myself, just from you. But what I see President Trump doing is also being in the mood of making deals, brokering peace, like he just did with Armenia and Azerbaijan, and also with Cambodia and Thailand. I think China and the United States can work together to broker peace for India and Pakistan, and even for Russia and Ukraine, and even for the Middle East to some extent.

The United States invited Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi there in February, and they are talking to all parties. That should also be the policy with China: talk to all parties. For the first time in six years, Prime Minister Modi is personally coming to China for the Shanghai Cooperation Organization summit, and also for a state visit. We are really looking forward to that. I think there is much room to talk, and we can really work things out with much better understanding, dialogue, and face-to-face meetings, rather than through outer space.

Republic TV: Of course, there have been several sticking points over the last decade, I would say. You've had the faceoff in Doklam and in Galwan between India and China. There have been skirmishes at the Line of Actual Control. Is it possible that both countries leave all of that behind? And looking ahead, Dr. Wang, what would be the areas of cooperation that you see as possible to take the India-China story forward?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Absolutely. This is so crucial. Since 1962, for the last 56 years, we haven't had any big events except for the last few years when we saw some trouble in those icy, unlivable, very remote areas. Why should we be so fussy about those unproductive areas? Let's maintain the status quo and conduct consultations through the current dialogue channels.

I think it's more important, with the challenges of war and nuclear proliferation in Europe and Gaza, and now possibly in our neighborhood, that we focus on cooperation to maintain peace. We should use our efforts to generate more economic cooperation.

China and India have so much in common. We have a lot to learn from each other. China can help India in many ways. China has developed the best infrastructure in the world. India is the largest recipient of loans from AIIB, which was founded in China. We also used to have many Indian students studying in China. During COVID, there were 20,000–30,000 Indian students in China. Now they have all gone back, but we hope they come back again.

We should do more on rural development, digital development, AI, environmental preservation, sustainable development, and green power. These are all areas we can collaborate on. I see a much bigger pie, much bigger interests compared with the little disputes we have. We should really put those disputes aside, focus on our major interests, and improve the livelihoods of both peoples. We must also resist this kind of pressure, like trade sanctions, trade wars, and tariffs. We have so much in common to work together on.

Republic TV: Look at the recent headlines. For example, I'm reading a headline from the Chinese envoys, a diplomat who said, "Give the bully an inch, he will take a mile." Beijing was trying to directly send a message while referring to India and what Donald Trump had tried to do with India vis-à-vis tariffs. How is China looking at someone like Donald Trump, and what has your response been? Do you feel BRICS, as a bloc, can unite now to finally send the United States a message?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Exactly. What the United States does is use tactics that break through every country individually. They have set tariffs for 100 countries and solved them one by one, because we are not a bloc, we are not united. I mean, we should be united—absolutely.

China is probably the only one that stood up and escalated tariffs with the US. Now they've come down in a more reasonable fashion, but China does have the strength. Like former US Secretary Blinken said, the United States always talks from a point of strength. China is probably doing that too. China is the only country that really stood up to this kind of pressure. But I think countries like India, the EU, Japan, Korea, Indonesia, and ASEAN—we should do the same. I do see huge potential in BRICS. The BRICS countries now have a GDP larger than the G7. We make up 40% of the global GDP and a much larger population. It's high time. India has been one of the leaders of the Global South, and China is the same.

We should work together, lead the BRICS countries, and make it more economically viable to resist unilateralism, trade wars, tariff wars, and all those unfair practices. It's time that big countries like China and India work together.

Republic TV: You did mention that you come from a point of strength, and that's why America had to pipe down vis-à-vis the tariffs and the big talk on China, especially. I want to tell you, India is also not yielding to America. We're also pushing back. You may have heard different comments coming from our own prime minister, who said that he will continue to fight for our farmers, and irrespective of the costs involved, he will take them head-on. We are ready for challenges. India's message has also been that we are not going to take the bullying from Donald Trump.

But there's another view in America now that perhaps Trump stands to lose by giving India this kind of treatment. Many are blaming him already for bringing India and China closer together, and we've seen noises from Delhi and Beijing. Do you think he's done that successfully?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Well, I think willingly or unwillingly, Trump is doing part of that. But I do see India as a very proud nation. You have a very long history, a very strong character, and a lot of talent. Just look at the United States—lots of big

companies, business schools, and financial institutions have many professors and leaders of Indian origin.

To some extent, I think pushing India away from the United States may be counterproductive. But it's also a timely wake-up call for India to think: why agonize over relations with China, why stay in a bad relationship? Why can't we stick together for the benefit of the Global South? We are two close neighbors and we should support each other. And of course, why should we be dictated to by just one country in the world that has been unfair many times? I think now people are starting to think twice. That's why we are paying a lot of attention to the current situation, and it's very interesting to see Prime Minister Modi coming to China to exchange views, compare notes, and see how we can strengthen cooperation for the benefit of the people of both countries, the Global South, and the world.

Republic TV: Okay, my final set of questions for you. You made a very interesting comment—you said maintain the status quo, and then take it forward from here. So, what's a good point to start with for China and India?

Henry Huiyao Wang: There have already been several rounds of talks, military to military, MFA to MFA, and so on. But this time, we should really grasp the opportunity of Prime Minister Modi's visit to China. Let's hammer out a joint statement saying, let's look forward, let's work in many ways, let's come up with ten areas of cooperation—environment, infrastructure, finance, people-to-people exchanges, and tourism. Let's open visas, get student exchanges going, and much more. Let's create a good mood and a good narrative. Let's study the history of both countries and revive common ground like Buddhism, which is popular in both countries. Let's work out a joint statement and look beyond. If we could maintain the status quo from 1962 until a few years ago, why can't we continue to maintain another 50 or 60 years? There's no reason we should fight over such silly, unnecessary things.

I think we should create a good atmosphere, a good narrative, improve understanding, and let those who want to say good things speak up. Diplomacy between heads of state like Prime Minister Modi and President Xi is so important. Let's revive the Wuhan spirit. I'm sure we could at least get back to normal relations, and that's what I hope.

Republic TV: Okay, great. Dr. Wang, thank you for speaking to Republic TV. We look forward to speaking to you again, because we feel it's a start. Let's see where this goes, because I think this time both countries are going in with a very honest intention, or at least that's the noise coming from China. And I see that the Indian side is also very keen to see where this goes from here.

Thank you for speaking to us and thank you for your time, Dr. Wang.

China Responded to US Bullying, but the Door to Dialogue Is Wide Open⁴

During the Antalya Diplomacy Forum, held from April 11 to 13, 2025, Henry Huiyao Wang, Founder and President of the Center for China and Globalization (CCG) was interviewed by TRT World, the English-language news service of Türkiye's national public broadcaster, the Turkish Radio and Television Corporation. The Forum is held under the patronage of Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan and hosted by Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan, bringing together heads of state and government, foreign ministers, leaders of international organizations, and representatives of civil society.

“China responded to US bullying, but the door to dialogue wide open”

Beijing has announced retaliatory tariffs of 125 percent on American goods in response to US President Donald Trump hiking tax on Chinese imports to a staggering 145 percent—marking the third hike since the “Liberation Day” announcement.

While the economic standoff between the world's two largest economies has raised fears of a prolonged trade war, a veteran Chinese policy advisor emphasized that Beijing is simply standing its ground with measured restraint.

“As the second-largest economy, China had no choice but to respond to Trump's tariffs—Beijing doesn't like to be bullied,” said Henry Huiyao Wang, founder and president of the Center for China and Globalization (CCG) and former Counselor to China's State Council—the country's highest administrative authority, overseeing various ministries and agencies to implement national policies and manage government affairs.

“But we still hope that dialogue, discussion, and sincere consultation can help resolve the differences—just like we managed to do during Trump's first term,” he told TRT World on the sidelines of the Antalya Diplomacy Forum 2025 on Friday.

However, Wang also appeared convinced that the current escalation has likely peaked.

“I think the tariff escalation has ended now,” he said, citing a recent announcement by China's Ministry of Commerce that Beijing would not retaliate further, even if Washington were to push its tariffs higher.

“China already announced they're not going to increase tariffs again... they will not follow that again.”

“The successive imposition of excessively high tariffs on China by the United States has become nothing more than a numbers game, with no real economic significance,” a spokesperson for China's Commerce Ministry said in a statement on Friday.

“It merely further exposes the US practice of weaponizing tariffs as a tool for bullying and coercion, turning itself into a joke,” the spokesperson added.

⁴ This featured report was published by TRT World.

Wang denounced the tit-for-tat approach as “counterproductive” and misaligned with the needs of a globalized world.

“Trade is beneficial to both the United States and China, and to the world. This is not just a bilateral issue—it has global ramifications,” he said, pointing to similar US trade actions against other partners, including Mexico, Canada, and the European Union.

“China, as one of the largest economies and a permanent member of the United Nations, has a responsibility to stand up for fair trade and multilateralism,” Wang said, adding that Beijing had already lodged a complaint with the World Trade Organization (WTO) dispute settlement mechanism.

Despite the optics of confrontation, Wang believes the situation has not yet crossed the point of no return. “This [tariff increase] almost means decoupling on trade. But even the Trump administration has said again and again—they don’t want to decouple from China or stop China’s development,” he said. “So now the question is: how do we get out of this escalation?.”

The answer, Wang argued, lies in diplomacy—and a dose of pragmatism.

Negotiations Still on the Table

While Beijing has had to respond to what it views as “bullying” tactics, Wang emphasized that China remains open to negotiations.

“China’s door for dialogue is wide open,” he said, stressing that high-level diplomacy is essential.

He pointed to the Trump administration’s Phase One trade deal as an example of what’s possible through talks. “Even during the first Trump term, after a period of tariff escalation, both sides came to the table and signed agreements.”

Wang suggested a revival of such exchanges, including visits by the US secretary of commerce or the US trade representative to China, or invitations to Chinese counterparts to Washington. “This is the time for communication and consultation—not confrontation,” he said.

Late Friday, the White House announced that Trump remained optimistic about securing a trade deal with China. “The president has made it very clear that he’s open to reaching an agreement with China,” White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt said during a press briefing. “But if China continues to retaliate, it won’t be in their best interest,” she added.

Wang suggested that the intention behind Trump’s tariffs, in the first place, were to use it as a bargaining chip for negotiations.

“Trump is a pragmatic businessman. He has said good things about China in the past, that he admires Chinese leadership and emphasised that if China and the US work together, nothing in the world is unsolvable.”

Wang also noted Trump’s early efforts to build ties with China, including inviting President Xi Jinping to his inauguration which was attended by Chinese Vice President Han Zheng. “But now, of course, he has a domestic political audience. He doesn’t want to lose face.”

He added that Washington's need for Beijing's cooperation on broader international issues—such as the Ukraine war, Middle East tensions, and North Korean denuclearization—could provide additional leverage for renewed dialogue.

Wang is hopeful. “Trump wants deals—on TikTok, on fentanyl, maybe even on peace. He once called himself the president of peace. So there's room to talk.”

Will China Sell US Sovereign Bonds?

Among the more dramatic scenarios floated by some analysts is the possibility of China retaliating by dumping US Treasury holdings, which would put pressure on the US dollar and global markets.

Wang, however, dismissed this as unlikely and unnecessary. “China is still quite reserved. It's not escalating further,” he said. While acknowledging that Beijing holds about \$800 billion in US Treasuries, Wang pointed out that these holdings are mutually beneficial.

“China is basically financing the US deficit. That's doing a lot of good for the US,” he said.

In his view, Washington's trade war misses the bigger picture: “It's short-sighted to focus only on manufacturing. The United States moved out of heavy industries years ago for reasons like pollution, labour cost, and environmental concerns. To now wage a trade war to bring that back doesn't make economic sense.”

He emphasized that “trade wars benefit nobody.”

“We need to come back to the negotiating table, because the costs of not doing so are just too high — not only for the US and China, but for the entire world economy.”

The China Alternative in Peacemaking and Mediation⁵

Henry Huiyao Wang, Founder and President of the Center for China and Globalization (CCG), was interviewed by Al Jazeera's "The Bottom Line" program in June, 2024. The title of the program was: "Israel's war on Gaza: The view from China," highlighting China's growing role in the Middle East, but wondering whether it can truly be a peacemaker between the Palestinians and Israelis.

The Bottom Line: Hi, I'm from The Bottom Line, and I have a question. China is playing a bigger role in the Middle East than ever, but can it compete with the United States to be a peacemaker between the Palestinians and Israelis? Let's get to the bottom line.

Last year, after years of hostility between Iran and Saudi Arabia, China was able to get both sides to agree in a day on something that the United States was either unable or unwilling to do. Now, with the war on Gaza in its 9th month, China has presented itself as a major power that's less biased toward Israel than the West. Beijing has criticized Israel for going well beyond self-defense and argued before the world court that the Palestinian use of force to resist oppression is their right and cannot be equated with terrorism.

For years, China has been expanding its economic footprint and criticizing the world order run by Washington, but will that translate to a bigger diplomatic and military role for Beijing in the Palestine-Israel conflict?

Today, we're talking with Wang Huiyao, president of the non-governmental think tank, the Center for China and Globalization, and he's a former adviser to the China State Council, which is China's cabinet. Dr. Wang, thank you so much for joining us today.

I know this is going to be an unusual show because typically we're talking about what Washington thinks about the world. Now, I'm really interested in what Beijing is thinking about the Israel-Gaza conflict, other conflicts, and really China's role in the world. So, I'd love to get your take on the Israel-Gaza conflict. How is Xi Jinping and Chinese leadership and Chinese population is looking at this conflict right now from your point of view?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Thank you, Steve. This war has been dragged on for quite some time now. It's more than half a year and it's really devastating to see people suffer there. The whole world is watching this on a daily basis, yet we cannot solve this crisis.

I think the Chinese government's position is very clear. China, condemns all kinds of violence or attacks on civilians. But China doesn't want to see this go beyond human security because we see a large number of civilian casualties and a humanitarian crisis unfolding. There have been international efforts and UN resolutions calling for a ceasefire, yet we still have not seen that happen.

It's really disappointing to many Chinese and really dismaying to the world to see this war still continuing on. We hope that we can see a ceasefire and real peacemaking.

⁵ This transcript is produced based on the video and hasn't been reviewed by the two speakers.

We'd like to see the international community, and of course, including China, working together to really stop this crisis, which has been going on for too long and on an unimaginable scale.

The Bottom Line: I was interested in various Chinese leaders' statements that from their perspective, Israel's actions right now in Gaza have gone beyond the rationale of self-defense, and I think that's a pretty bold statement from China compared to others that have been made. To be honest, I think there are Americans that may rightly or wrongly think they are fair to both sides, wanting to be fair to and protect Palestinians, but they have this relationship with Israel that seems to have no boundaries.

I'm interested in how you see this and whether you see America in sort of a hypocritical moment and whether or not China is willing to weigh in more greatly to basically say to Israel, back off.

Henry Huiyao Wang: That's quite possible and I think that's exactly what's happening. The United States used to be the world's policeman; they are trying to maintain a certain post-World War order, but they really look very incompetent now, particularly in terms of this crisis. We're seeing a double standard applied in this situation. Certainly, Israel has considerable influence in the United States, but we even see that influence diminishing.

Prime Minister Netanyahu, who still hangs on to power, has taken the war beyond what is necessary in terms of retaliation. I think it's over 10 times more, which is beyond imagination—the suffering of the people, 1.5 million Palestinians have been relocated in the Gaza Strip, and particularly the hunger, the casualties, the children, the women, and all the suffering we see on a daily basis in our living rooms.

So, China has stepped up its efforts and has been talking to all involved, including a ministerial summit with Arab nations. I think China is really hopeful that we can really solve this with a two-state solution, stop the fighting, have a ceasefire, get a UN resolution in place, and really put this to an end.

It's really alarming and unbearable to see such a crisis going on with such a large number of civilians in danger. It's totally beyond control, very unfortunate and very tragic. The Chinese government and Chinese people are really paying more and more attention to this crisis now and want to get involved.

There is a great desire on the Chinese side to see peacemaking move forward. Recently, the Chinese government announced they are going to donate 500 million RMB for humanitarian aid to the people in Gaza and they're calling to reopen all the channels and rescue efforts so we can see the situation improve and see the crisis stop.

The Bottom Line: We all woke up in Washington DC one day to the news that China had played this key role in normalizing relations between Saudi Arabia and Iran, and I tell you, it was a whiplash effect. People said, "My goodness, that was sort of America's terrain, that's sort of what we did." And China, in a way, jumped into a role that we hadn't seen before. I'd love to get your insights, not only on Israel-Gaza, but also China's surprising new diplomatic mission around the region. What is driving that right now?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Absolutely. I think China now is increasing its soft power, using Joseph Nye's term, but because China has opened up. In the last 45 years, China has grown to become the second-largest economy and the largest trading nation of over 120 countries. Stability and prosperity are vital to China's growth and prosperity.

You mentioned about the peace deal between Saudi Arabia and Iran, which is great because China is the largest trading nation with both countries. China buys around 90% of their energy exports and that's really a big factor. I think that the Arab nations, particularly Saudi Arabia and Iran, don't want to be in such an agonizing position. They want a ladder to come down, but they don't want to do it with the United States or Europe because they've been part of many wars and conflicts in the Middle East. So they need somebody nice and clean, need somebody credible, and somebody that has never invaded or occupied any of their territories, somebody like China, which is also their largest trading partner.

It's very natural for them to come to China, and China is willing to work harder to make peace. It's in the Chinese interest and in the interest of world prosperity. I think this is how this deal between Iran and Saudi Arabia happened, because China really wants to show that they are friendly with both countries.

When China says, "Please don't do it, let's stop. Give me face and stop it," they will probably do it because they respect China as their largest trading partner. So, I see this happening in the partner Middle East, and possibly even for the Gaza conflict. China is the largest trading partner of all the Arab nations and the second-largest trade nation with Israel.

China has maintained good relations with both Arab countries and Israel and the time may come for China to step in and say, "Look, let's really end this and solve this issue." And probably China, particularly now with the Global South, would have more influence.

China recently developed a six-point plan with Brazil for the war between Ukraine and Russia. Someone from the Turkish Foreign Ministry came to CCG a few days ago in Beijing, saying that Türkiye is also willing to work with China to help resolve conflicts in the Middle East and Ukraine. So, I think China can play a more active role in peacemaking and peace-mediating than before. Mainly because China has a vested interest in seeing a more prosperous, more stable, more peaceful world, which benefits both China and the world.

The Bottom Line: Do you think there's a pathway with international institutions to be more effective in these conflicts, because my view is that the Secretary-General wants it, but can't do it. Is there a resolution besides just having constant paralysis when we're trying to deal with these horrible bleeding ulcers in the world that involve real people's lives?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Absolutely. I think that the UN and the Security Council could do much more. The problem I see now is that there are so many problems in the world and so much conflict on top of climate change. Secretary-General Guterres mentioned today that we should stop advertising gasoline among other things.

I think the major powers, should really get their act together and work together. On the issue of Gaza, I don't really see that why can't we send in a UN peacekeeping force and separate the conflict parties, then put a two-state solution in place?

The fundamental challenge is that the major powers sometimes have different views and conflicts among themselves that lead to sanctions and trade wars. This makes it difficult to reach a consensus, but even if the United Nations reaches a consensus, sometimes it doesn't have the power to enforce it. It's really absurd that the Security Council of the UN, which is the rock of world peace that was established after the Second World War, made up of such powerful countries, can't stop a small regional war in Gaza.

I really think the United Nations should strengthen its enforcing power. UN peacekeeping forces should be actively deployed to stop the fighting in Gaza. And the two-state solution, which was proposed by European countries and China—even the United States doesn't object to it—why can't we implement that?

If there's a consensus for a two-state solution, then let's do it. We have to fundamentally solve that problem, otherwise it's detrimental not only for domestic politics but also international politics. We are paralyzed and find out there's some new challenge and new crisis. We have to really get our act together and stop this war and make peace.

The Bottom Line: Such a powerful comment. Let me ask you a question more about a geostrategic picture in economics. You know, Israel, the UAE, India, and the United States have announced a new effort to open a corridor from Asia to Europe, maybe a different form of a Belt and Road Initiative. Japan has announced a new global partnership with the United States. Is China feeling any of that pressure, or are you feeling very comfortable with what you've got?

Henry Huiyao Wang: No, I actually view this positively. Around ten years ago, nobody was thinking about start any global development projects, but China did it. China proposed the Belt and Road Initiative eleven years ago, which is great. Now, it's real and has had an impact. Countries are starting to really look at this global infrastructure deficit.

Later, the United States proposed Build Back Better World (B3W), and the EU proposed the EU Global Gateway, and now we have India, the UAE, and Europe saying, "Okay, let's make an India, Middle East, Europe, Economic Corridor." Great, if these countries want to put out more investment into more projects, it would be very good.

But the problem now is that we see a lot of plans being proposed, but not a lot of action. Over the last decade, the Belt and Road Initiative has invested over 1 trillion US dollars and built 3,000 projects in developing countries. What about other countries? We need concrete results, but that's yet to be seen.

If there's a consensus on the global infrastructure deficit, I'd like to see us work together. Let's combine the efforts of the B3W, the Global Gateway, the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor. But who would do that? Let's use the World Bank, let's use the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB), the Asian Development

Bank, the African Development Bank, or the European Development Bank. These banks share similar charters. And why can't they work together?

But I really see that climate change is one of the big consensus in addition to solving the infrastructure deficit, so let's work together rather than going in different directions, uncoordinated, and creating a lot of redundancy and waste. I would really like to see we can work together. China welcomes that and President Xi has said B3W is welcome, so is the Global Gateway and other similar initiatives. Let's work together. That's the Chinese approach.

The Bottom Line: Henry, let me ask you a question about Russia-China. I'm sorry, Russia-Ukraine, since you mentioned that. Do you suspect there are more things that China can do in terms of playing mediator, nudging its friend without boundaries, Russia, in and Ukraine, into an arrangement that would end the war and conflict?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Absolutely. China feels this has really got out of hand. From the very beginning when the war broke out, China said that territorial integrity should be respected. And when Olaf Scholz came to Beijing, President Xi said, "No nuclear weapons should be used in Ukraine." And then when President Macron came, President Xi called President Zelenskyy right after that.

China is really a substantial player now and Ambassador Le was traveling to those related countries. If the NATO and Western-led coalition is not able to put an end to this war, then the Global South will get really annoyed. Countries like Brazil, Türkiye, India, and South Africa all want to mediate and do something. China is on great terms with countries not party to conflict. Russia is fighting with NATO and the EU, but China and all the other Global South countries are not part of it, so, they are in a good position to be mediators and peacemakers.

China just issued a statement with Brazil and the Turkish foreign ministers came to Beijing and agreed on many of those points. I see China more and more as a peacemaker and mediator in this crisis. Of course, we would love to work with the United States and the EU, but China's position is clear—let's get all parties to the conflict to make peace together rather than it being just one-sided. Let's get both sides to come together to talk about how to end this war through dialogue, through negotiations, through communication. I think that is really the Chinese way.

The Bottom Line: Well, one of the questions is, is BRICS itself paralyzed in its efforts? Are the tensions between India and China within BRICS keeping it from playing this role? Do you take the BRICS notion seriously as an alternative way to think about how power and global problem-solving gets done. This is our last question, but I would love to hear your thoughts.

Henry Huiyao Wang: I think this is a great question. BRICS represents economic globalization and that's the attraction we see now. The number of BRICS countries doubled last year and the purchasing power parity of BRICS is already larger than the G7. There's also another 20-some countries lined up to join BRICS. The Turkish Foreign Minister told me at CCG that he's going to attend the BRICS Plus summit the next week.

It's really important to know that even though we have ideological or administrative differences, BRICS countries all favor economic globalization and favor economic development, and that's the attraction of BRICS. In all the other alliances, security is emphasized with the expansion of NATO, the creation of AUKUS and the Quad, and even Camp David. These alliances don't really produce the bread and butter and really only increase the military budgets of all those countries.

I think we have to keep the prosperity that we've achieved and we can't risk endangering that. So, I think we have to really push continuously for economic globalization and that's exactly what China is doing through the Belt and Road Initiative, the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, and by applying to join the CPTPP and being a part of the RCEP, the largest free trade agreement in the world. China wants economic cooperation with African, Latin American, Central Asian and Gulf countries. China is a big country pursuing economic globalization.

This is what BRICS is about. They want to be part of economic globalization. And even though BRICS still has much to improve, it represents the right direction for economic globalization. So with the Global North focusing so much on security issues and increasing their military budgets, BRICS countries and the Global South is getting squeezed. More people are facing hunger and poverty, and that's why I think BRICS represents a new alternative of economic globalization that is becoming more and more attractive.

The Bottom Line: Fascinating, Wang Huiyao, Founder and President of the Center for China and Globalization, I really appreciate you for joining us today. Thank you for your candor.

Henry Huiyao Wang: Thank you, Steve.

The Bottom Line: So, what's the bottom line? Everybody hates the enforcer of the rules, but the hard truth is that the world needs enforcers whether we like it or not. Why? Because some conflicts cut so deep that the warring antagonists just can't find the balance that delivers safety and justice from each other. So, the enforcers make global rules which, of course, tilt in their favor. For almost a century, the United States has believed that it alone was the premier diplomatic, economic, and security force solving global disputes and, of course, resolves things its way. But more recently, other countries are entering the field. China's reasons are clear: geopolitical competition with the United States. I don't think China has deep roots and concerns about either Palestine or Israel, but on the other hand, if it can get some credit with Arab states and Iran by playing a balancing role in the crisis, then all the better. And that's the bottom line.

Small Countries and Major Powers—Partners in a Multilateral World⁶

The annual Bled Strategic Forum international conference took place on 2 and 3 September 2024 in Bled, Slovenia, under the title, “A World of Parallel Realities.” Representatives from the Center for China and Globalization (CCG), the only Chinese think tank invited to the event, included President Henry Huiyao Wang, Secretary-General Mabel Lu Miao, and John Zhao, Director of External Relations and Manager of the Global Young Leaders Dialogue program.

During the forum, Wang was interviewed by RTV Slovenija, the Slovenian national broadcaster, about global challenges, China-US relations, China’s perception in the West, the South China Sea, and Taiwan.

RTV Slovenija: Dr. Wang, it is an honor to have you with us at this strategic forum. The world is getting more and more complicated, and it also seems getting much tougher. How do you see the current situation in the world from the Chinese perspective?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Thank you for having me. Actually, this is my second time at the Bled Strategic Forum. I was quite struck by the forum’s theme as well as the impact and soft power that Slovenia can harness, gathering thought leaders, European leaders, and even United Nations leaders. I think the world is at a crossroads—the world is on fire—and there are not enough people calling for concerted efforts to put it out. That’s why I it’s great to see Slovenia, which is not a big country, playing such a big role in terms of building consensus and calling attention to the crisis we’re having now. Particularly, for example, last night, there was a performance where Palestinians and Israelis got together to sing for peace. That was amazing. I was quite impressed. The world is in deep trouble with climate change, geopolitics, and conflicts including the Russia-Ukraine war and Pakistan-Israel conflict, but we need people who stand up and call for unity so we can face this all together and meet the challenges.

RTV Slovenija: Well, in Slovenia, there’s quite a popular joke that we see ourselves as so small that all Slovenians would fit into a hotel in Beijing. So, you see a possibility for such a small country, now also part of the UN Security Council, to do something good for the world?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Absolutely. Slovenia is a beautiful country. It also has a rich culture and incredible diversity. I saw the performance twice at the Strategic Forum and it was very impressive. The world today is getting so many divisions, conflicts, and crises, we need more people, not only the big powers but also small and beautiful countries like Slovenia, to call attention to issues and to tell the truth.

I think the opening speech by Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Foreign Affairs, Ms. Tanja, was quite impressive. She was calling for unity, attention, justice,

⁶ This transcript is produced based on the video and hasn’t been reviewed by the two speakers.

and peace. I think those voices, particularly when you gather crowds from around the world, are important to show that Slovenia has this kind of soft power and also the eagerness to express its strong support. I was really impressed.

RTV Slovenija: You're probably a commentator on all sorts of affairs, especially economic affairs. You know China, you know the United States, Canada, and you know Europe. Why is the world like this? Why has it become like this?

Henry Huiyao Wang: That's a good question. Why has the world become this now? I think there are several reasons. First of all, for the last eighty years since the Second World War, the world has been largely at peace, but as globalization encountered setbacks like increasing inequality in some countries between rich and poor. Second, the world is also becoming multipolar and the unipolar world is probably gone, so there's an adjustment period. Third, there's also the rise of China, which has become the world's second-largest economy and China's rise takes some time for many people to get used to. So there's a lot of blame and scapegoating going around, but I think what we should do is really should strengthen the multinational system, specifically the UN system. Major countries and regions like the EU, China, the United States, and the Global South should work together.

Issues linked to information technology, AI, climate change, and of course the wealth gap between countries have all contributed to de-globalization, nationalism, populism, war, and increased numbers of refugees. All of these things have contributed to the crisis we're now facing. I think now we need some leadership and Slovenia is taking some leadership. You're calling attention to all the major countries and the UN system. Slovenia is going to be the Chair of the Security Council in the near future, which is very important for demonstrating more leadership.

RTV Slovenija: Globalization is also one of the main topics you focus on as a phenomenon. You also mentioned de-globalization. How far could de-globalization go? And what would that mean for China, which is a champion of globalization?

Henry Huiyao Wang: We are in a very dangerous period. De-globalization is happening and if wars like the Russian war on Ukraine evolve into a Third World War, we're probably all going to go back to the Stone Age. De-globalization will certainly continue. Even in the Israel-Palestinian conflict, we already see spill over the region, affecting the Red Sea region, impacting global trade, global economics, global investment, and global confidence.

China, as the largest trading nation of 140 countries, attracts foreign investment and invests in other countries despite headwinds. But all that geopolitical tension could really reduce confidence. So, I think this is a crisis that we have to be extremely careful about. My personal view is that we really need the United States, the EU, and China to work together and come up with a consensus instead of fighting among each other or playing at rivals. We should be partners and work together to solve global challenges. That's what I think the solution is. You need all the big players to work together. But we also need countries like Slovenia calling for justice and third-country impartial views on how things should be done to persuade all countries to work together, particularly in the UN.

RTV Slovenija: Right now when you mentioned the United States, the EU, and China, there's something going on that is quite stunning—the tariffs on e-cars from China. The United States and Canada are imposing tariffs. Now also the EU, although not as severe as the United States. Do you see this as a symptom of something which will go away? Or do you see this as an announcement that something bigger is going on, the geopolitical tensions?

Henry Huiyao Wang: It started with the United States when President Trump started the trade war and the tariff war. That pattern was continued by President Biden and Biden even added a 100% tariff on EVs despite China not really exporting many EV cars to the United States. Now Europe is doing it too, but I think Europe did that before the United States, which was followed by Canada. I think it's a bad approach because China was only responding to the trade war and the tariffs. China wasn't the initiator.

We are in a world where climate change and disasters are everywhere. Temperatures are going up and natural disasters are happening all around the world. We need more clean energy. Europe and China now have more renewable energy, which is a great thing, but we should not block green technology or products. China didn't block Airbus or Boeing because it's produced in Western countries. Did China stop buying them and put tariffs on them? No, and vice versa. Germany still exports more diesel engine and gasoline engine cars to China than China exports EV cars to Germany.

There are a lot of double standards and you can't say China should always produce textiles, shoes, or sweaters, and put barriers up and slap tariffs on things if China develops some more sophisticated technology; that's not the right approach. We should all work together. China can produce very cheap solar panels to generate power. If China can do it cheaply, let China subsidize the world, especially developing countries. Let's share that technology. I think the EU and China should work together, and with the United States, to help the Global South develop clean energy.

I think it was a bad move to treat China as a rival and start talking about overcapacity, of which there is none. The International Energy Agency (IEA) forecasted that we need 820 gigawatts of new photovoltaic installations, but we only can provide 20% of that. We need to spend 4.5 trillion US dollars on renewable energy annually, but we only spent 1.8 trillion in 2023. We're far from oversupply. We're actually short of supply. I think we need to work on that.

RTV Slovenija: There's a lot of mistrust in the West toward China because of its political system and human rights. There are also political tensions, especially in the South China Sea. There is, of course, a lot of mistrust also on the Chinese side toward the West, in which point: How do you in China see the West? What is the reason for this distrust, including the colonial past?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Since 1840 when the Opium War was started and the British invaded China, the country experienced a century of humiliations. But I think China has already got out of that. China is now talking about building a shared future for mankind and has invited more than 50 African leaders to Beijing for the China-Africa summit, the largest gathering of state leaders in China in recent years.

China wants to get along with the West. What China is saying is that the West has a very good model that works for the West, which has a long history based in Christianity and a diverse culture. Well, China has its own model as well. China has 5,000 years of civilization which was never interrupted. China has a meritocracy where officials are selected through examinations in a tradition that is thousands of years old. China has a consultative democracy where people gather together to debate and criticize the ruling party, but constructively. This is the model that China has adopted. China also has a long-term vision and long-term plans with one five-year plan after another. One party debating another party and vetoing for the sake of vetoing does not happen in China. There are some problems in China, but overall China has done very well and become the world's second-largest economy, lifting 800 million people out of poverty, 70% of the global total. They must have done something right.

RTV Slovenija: The United States is, let's say, a hard power and a big military power. Europe is considered as a big soft power. China is considered in the West as a monolith and that's why there are some fears, because facing such a big monolith is difficult to imagine. But is China really a monolith?

Henry Huiyao Wang: No, I don't think so. For example, I had a very long dialogue with both Prof. Graham Allison and Prof. Joseph Nye. Both former colleagues of mine from Harvard when I was doing my senior fellowship there. Prof. Joseph Nye was saying, that the United States is big enough, China is big enough. The United States cannot change China. China cannot change the United States. Relations are at the bottom of a 20 year cycle. Eventually, we will probably just have to accept each other.

I recently published a book that documented my dialogue with Graham Allison, the founding Dean of Harvard Kennedy School, called *Escaping Thucydides's Trap*, which is a concept that the world's ruling power and the new rising power are bound to come into conflict. But he says that isn't necessary. We can avoid that.

There's a concern because the United States and China have different systems, different cultures, and different ethnicities. People may not know that well, so people have certain fears in the West. But this year China opened visa-free travel for almost 15 EU countries. I just met a leader from an Italian think tank here at Bled. She just came back from Beijing the day before this conference. She told me she hadn't been there for ten years and she was really surprised that the sky was blue and the smog is gone in Beijing. People are more confident and Beijing has changed enormously with new transportation links and all the green technology. She was very impressed. She spent 10 days in China as a tourist using the visa-free policy. I hope that more people will visit and that their perception of China will improve, because if they go and see it, they will see how we live. We don't have any big differences. We should get together.

RTV Slovenija: Because of the role China is playing now in the modern world, and it is a huge role, some people are actually asking themselves, since we have this war now between Russia and Ukraine, which some consider it as a war between Russia

and the West, could China do more with its subtle diplomacy you're talking a lot about? Could you do more to bring peace to the region?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Absolutely. I think China can do more. For example, I think there's already fatigue on both sides. Also, both presidential candidates in the current US election have said they want to end the war. Trump said he'll end the war in 24 h or even before he's inaugurated. If the United States or the West in general wants to end this war, they need the support of China, because China is the largest trading partner of Russia. And China carries a lot of political clout with Russia.

China said no nuclear weapons should be used in the fight between Russia and Ukraine. Apparently, that warning has played some role there. What I think is that now there is fatigue on both sides, and US public opinion would not support this war continuously like it would for Israel. China could come in as a third neutral party that can bring both sides together because China is the largest trading partner of both Ukraine and Russia. Of course, when China sits at the table it could really make a huge difference in reaching a ceasefire.

RTV Slovenija: But one thing is very interesting when it comes to China. The People's Republic of China hasn't been involved in a war since the 1970s in Vietnam. So it's really fascinating looking at the world right now where there are wars going on. What is concerning perhaps from the European perspective is the situation in the South China Sea. We talk about the Philippines and Vietnam also, but has it to do mainly with the so-called Taiwan problem?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I think there are two separate issues. There's the Taiwan issue, wherein Taiwan is always part of China, like when the United States and P. R. China established diplomatic ties, the US recognized Taiwan as part of China. Similarly, 183 countries all recognize Taiwan as part of China and the Chinese government as the legitimate representative of the whole of China. So that principle is there, that policy is there.

I think there's some tension because China always responds to moves like Nancy Pelosi's visit, which breached the unspoken agreement to have no official ties with Taiwan. China had to do something. When President Tsai Ing-wen visited the United States, again China had to do something. Or when the United States sends military aircraft around Taiwan, China has to do something. China is always responding.

But China wants peaceful reunification. China has said many times that it is the priority and preferred approach. In Fujian Province, just across from Taiwan, the government has said it will give Taiwanese local benefits in schooling, employment, and medical care. There are already 1 or 2 million Taiwanese working in the mainland and there are another half million husbands and wives married across the Taiwan Strait. They share the same language, culture, and traditions. I think in the long run, they're going to be peacefully integrated. Just yesterday, China announced that people from Fujian Province could travel to Taiwan, so we can integrate if there's no foreign interference.

RTV Slovenija: It is an interesting detail. Taiwan, of course, is a very important economic power, the world's biggest producer of semiconductors. Actually, the semiconductor industry in Taiwan is a sort of guarantee for a sort of status quo that all can live with—China and the international community. How do you see this?

Henry Huiyao Wang: China is happy with this status quo, as long as they do not declare independence or become a platform for international anti-China rhetoric. US companies are very smart. Apple doesn't use IBM or Intel; it uses the TSMC from Taiwan to produce semiconductors. And they use Foxconn to produce hardware in the mainland, which is another Taiwanese company. They became the largest company in the world because they tapped into the resources and talent of Greater China. It's so smart because if they used IBM or Intel, they probably would not be the largest company in the world. Now we're seeing that being threatened with this potential conflict. It's not in the US interest to do that, nor is it in the Chinese interest. I think it's important that we maintain this economic freedom.

Now the United States has passed the CHIPS Act, which isn't just the United States not selling to China, they have forbidden Taiwan, Japan, the Netherlands, and South Korea to sell chips to China. That's really too much because it hurts US companies. China buys 30% of the world's chips. If they lose that business, it'll hurt their R&D. I don't know how long they can sustain that. I hope the new president will take a smarter approach rather than this self-defeating approach.

RTV Slovenija: My last question is this. Regarding your optimism from the beginning that small Slovenia could do something and that big players in the world should actually collaborate, because it's only one world with very similar problems, how do you, as an expert, see the foreseeable future?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Before answering your question, I'd like to touch on this South China Sea issue you mentioned. I think China gets along with all ASEAN countries. China gets along with Vietnam and Vietnam's Party Secretary-General just visited Beijing ten days ago. And then Malaysia, Indonesia, all those countries have some issues in the South China Sea, but we don't have any problems. We are getting along very well. China got along with the Philippines also very well when the predecessor of Marcos was in power for two terms. China never had an issue with him. Recently, we have had some issues because the United States has reopened nine military bases in the Philippines and increased their military presence. They keep breaking the status quo. So China has to defend whatever it has claimed. Of course, I think there's a way to do it. We should follow the China-ASEAN summit and the South China Sea Code of Conduct. We're working on the principles of that, but let's work out the details. If Vietnam, Indonesia, Malaysia, Brunei, and all the other ASEAN countries have no problem with China or can coexist peacefully, why can't the Philippines do that? There must be a way to do it, rather than being backed by the nine US military bases and continuing to challenge China on the existing status quo.

So finally, on Slovenia's role, which is very impressive, particularly in terms of the Bled Strategic Forum. Slovenia is not a big country but it can play a big role.

It's a UN Security Council member and the chairman as well and has enormous soft power in setting agendas, leading discussions, creating new narratives, telling new stories, changing people's minds, and injecting new momentum and dynamism into the global discourse. I think a beautiful place like Bled can have an enormous contribution. That's why I think we shouldn't underestimate what Slovenia can do. It is really doing big things.

The Center for China and Globalization, as one of China's most active think tanks, would love to collaborate with Bled Strategic Forum. We have actually hosted Deputy Prime Minister and the Foreign Minister Fajon. She visited our think tank and delivered a great speech in China. We've invited UN ambassadors, including the Japanese ambassador, and the newly appointed Chinese climate envoy, Minister Liu Zhenmin, when your Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister spoke at CCG. This is a good example of how we can work together to amplify Slovenian voices and to hear the Chinese view so we can work together and build a better future.

RTV Slovenija: Dr. Wang, thank you very much for the interview, and enjoy Slovenia.

Henry Huiyao Wang: Thank you.

A More Open China Is a More Secure China⁷

The 15th annual Aspen Security Forum was hosted by the Aspen Strategy Group, in Colorado from July 16–19, 2024. Dr. Henry Huiyao Wang, President of the Center for China and Globalization (CCG), and Dr. Mabel Lu Miao, Secretary-General of CCG were the only Chinese representatives invited to participate. Over the four-day event, they engaged in face-to-face exchanges with many prominent figures from the US government, strategic community, think tanks, diplomatic delegations, NGOs, businesses, and media, promoting China-US people-to-people and think tank exchanges. During the forum, Henry Huiyao Wang gave an exclusive interview with Phoenix News.

Sticking to the “Small Yard, High Fence” Strategy: Anti-China Sentiment as American Political Correctness

Phoenix: At this year’s Aspen Security Forum, you mentioned that China is not just a topic but has become a backdrop—almost every panel touches on China to some extent. What impressed you the most at this forum? How do you think the Aspen Security Forum differs from the Munich Security Conference or other security forums you have attended?

Henry Huiyao Wang: The Aspen Security Forum is probably the highest level forum on international relations in the United States. The attendees include key officials from the US government and military, as well as media, think tanks, and major enterprises. The forum focuses on various aspects of international security, including military, economic, technological, and strategic security. Although there are participants from other countries, the majority are still Americans. The forum involves US policymakers, strategic decision-makers, and think tank experts, giving it a distinctly US stance.

Phoenix: Under the tight schedule, the first session was focused on addressing the “China Challenge.” This session did not mention much traditional international relations theories but emphasized economic security and US-China tech competition. Several speakers mentioned the “small yard, high fence” strategy. It seems that the US political and academic circles are quite satisfied with this strategy as well as its resulting measures, such as sanctions on Huawei and restricting Chinese access to advanced chips. What is your view on their perspectives?

Henry Huiyao Wang: The incumbent US administration views its series of policies against China as effective, including initial moves toward “decoupling” and later “derisking” actions including the CHIPS and Science Act, and the “small yard, high fence” strategy. However, the American business community does not entirely agree with this opinion. Some in the forum questioned whether the United States should focus more on introspection, think more about how to enhance its competitiveness

⁷ This transcript is translated from the Chinese version of the exclusive Phoenix News interview. The original text is accessible online.

rather than shifting the blame onto others; they also mentioned the need for more engagement, communication, and even cooperation between the United States and China.

I believe that while the “small yard, high fence” strategy aligns with the current bipartisan consensus on China, it faces many challenges in implementation. Many businesses are not enthusiastic about it, and it has affected economic and trade exchanges between China and the United States.

Nevertheless, I believe that China needs to further open up, attract more American businesses to China, and “retain” US companies within China to prevent the complete decoupling caused by the “small yard, high fence” strategy. Such decoupling would be detrimental to both the United States and China.

Phoenix: You mentioned the attitudes of businesses. Some companies have said that due to the “small yard, high fence” strategy, they are unable to achieve significant profits in China, which impacts their subsequent technological investments. However, some panelists have argued that this is not the case and that companies operating in China are doing well. As you have had contact with many foreign enterprises in China, what is their true attitude toward this situation?

Henry Huiyao Wang: The primary attitude of foreign, especially American, companies in China, is to focus on “quietly reaping profits.” When it comes to political statements, such as those concerning the strategic consensus of the US Congress and administration toward China, they often avoid taking a stance or do so only superficially. This is because they have to deal with American public opinion, the US stock market, and American media. If they show favor toward China, they may face political pressure.

China somehow shows more openness in this regard. CCG recently hosted a delegation from a private high school in Washington, which included the children of many State Department officials. They found that what they saw in China was quite different from what they had been told.

I think the same applies to the business community. China needs to attract more American companies, as their prospects in China are promising. For example, I just met with a MasterCard executive at the forum who mentioned that MasterCard receives more support in China than in India now. Companies can establish themselves in China, whereas entering the Indian market still poses many challenges. He hopes that China will continue to open its door wider, as attracting American businesses and providing level playing field could indirectly influence American policymakers.

Phoenix: The US government seems to think that it can set clear boundaries to the “small yard, high fence” strategy or US-China trade, and that they believe the “yard” within the boundaries can remain the same size. However, in reality, the “yard” keeps expanding and the “fence” keeps rising. For instance, Chinese private companies collaborating with researchers with military backgrounds will be quickly labeled as military technology by US think tanks, making those companies prone to

be blacklisted. Do you think there are boundaries to the slippery slope of the “small yard, high fence” strategy?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Since the Biden administration took office, it has aligned with bipartisan consensus and has been even more confrontational toward China than the Trump administration. A series of measures including the “small yard, high fence” strategy, the CHIPS and Science Act, and increased tariffs on Chinese electric vehicles have surpassed the measures taken during the Trump administration, causing significant negative impacts on US-China trade relations.

The “small yard, high fence” strategy only consists of a yard and a fence without any boundaries, making it so general that almost any technology could be placed in the “yard.” Therefore, the best way to counteract this is to continually expand China’s openness, making the scope of its open areas broader and the thresholds for access lower, thereby offsetting the so-called “small yard, high fence” approach from the United States. While the United States is building fences and imposing restrictions, China should go against this trend by expanding its openness and removing the barriers of these “fences.”

Phoenix: China should build more bridges and attract others like a stronger magnet.

Henry Huiyao Wang: Exactly. To cater to mainstream American political correctness, those who are at this forum were all spreading unfavorable narratives about China. However, to influence or change their misconceptions about China, we need more openness, as mentioned in the Third Plenum, which calls for building a higher level open economic system.

Addressing Chokepoints in Cutting-Edge Technology and the Relationship Between Openness and Security

Phoenix: The issue of chips is a major concern. The US strategy involves leveraging its alliances; for example, it tries to control China’s access to photolithography machines and raw materials through its close partnerships with Japan, South Korea and the Netherlands, so as to create a chokepoint. How do you assess the effectiveness of this strategy in practice? Can the development of China’s “neck-choking” industries, especially the chip sector, be better promoted through foreign talent recruitment or other methods?

Henry Huiyao Wang: After several days of meetings, I’ve observed a clear trend in the United States: there is a strong desire to avoid direct conflict with China despite a clear intention of restricting China’s development. The aim is not necessarily to plan for a hot war against China but rather to use various indirect methods to contain China’s growth. This has already become a consensus in the United States. The “small yard, high fence” strategy and the CHIPS and Science Act all serve this purpose. The CHIPS and Science Act, in particular, is not a unilateral action by the United States; it involves a coalition with the Netherlands, Japan, South Korea, and Taiwan to jointly contain the Chinese mainland. To address this, China needs to intensify its efforts in independent R&D and production, and it must also maintain international

cooperation. China should strengthen collaboration with other countries and regions to circumvent the so-called “small yard, high fence.”

Given the impending US election, the duration of these measures is still uncertain, so it's all the more important for China to strengthen international cooperation. For American chip companies, the inability to sell more than half of their chips to China represents a significant loss and negatively impacts their R&D, while also providing China with a chance to expand its development further.

Regarding talent, the meeting highlighted that half of the AI talent in the United States comes from China, which is a significant number. Representatives from OpenAI also mentioned a desire to strengthen efforts to attract Chinese talent. I believe the same applies to China; China needs to attract talent from around the world, especially Chinese students studying abroad and IT professionals from countries like the United States, EU, Japan, and India, to enhance China's technological innovation capabilities.

President Xi has emphasized the importance of attracting talent extensively. China can do more in this area. Recently, China has opened up visa-free travel for many EU countries, and I believe it would be beneficial to also open up visa-free travels for US citizens and improve the domestic “green card” system to attract more foreigners to China.

Phoenix: Anja Manuel, the Executive Director of the Aspen Security Forum, said that areas of intense competition between China and the United States, such as high technology, will gradually experience “derisking,” while economic, agricultural, and cultural exchanges will become more “entangled.” Do you think this approach is feasible? Will decoupling in some areas impact mutual trust and cooperation in others?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Anja Manuel's explanation of the “small yard, high fence” strategy is to control America's cutting-edge technology, but to encourage as much cooperation as possible in other areas, such as with companies like Coca-Cola, Starbucks, McDonald's, and Walmart. I think that makes certain sense. The expansion of cooperation in non-security sectors, which is profitable for American companies, can help garner more public support for China-US relations.

The economic losses in high-end industries, already significant despite being in their early stages, have sparked strong opposition from companies in the Netherlands, Japan, and South Korea, and even in Taiwan. As related American companies face increasing losses, opposition to business decoupling is likely to grow. Currently, American companies in China, including Apple and Tesla, are making substantial profits, and these major firms will also voice their concerns. Therefore, the duration of the current government's “small yard, high fence” strategy will depend on its effectiveness.

More importantly, American investments should be able to become deeply embedded in the vast sea of China's economy, making decoupling impossible. If they attempt to decouple, China should strengthen the ties; if they sever connections, China should build bridges. By fostering a community with closely intertwined interests, greater conflicts can be avoided.

Phoenix: As you mentioned, China should build an even more open economic system. If the United States uses measures like “chokepoints” to influence China, will this lead to insecurity on the Chinese part and affect China’s openness to the outside world?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Indeed, the 3rd Plenary Session of the 20th Central Committee of the Communist Party of China emphasized balancing development and security, but it also introduced a new concept—“promoting reform through opening-up.” This means that the more open the country is, the greater the impetus for reform and, consequently, the greater the security. Therefore, the more open China is, the more secure China becomes. The Third Plenum is a real revelation to me as it points out that despite the complex and high-pressure international situation, the country is still emphasizing opening-up, development, and the market economy, not on self-reliance or isolated domestic circulation. This has surpassed my expectations.

Given the complex and adverse external environment, the country should have focused more on self-reliance. However, the current discourse emphasizes increased openness, reform, and market-driven policies. The notion that “the more open China is, the more secure China becomes” highlights how security serves openness. This is crucial. As the Chinese saying goes, one should not give up eating for fear of choking; instead, China should continue opening-up, which is key to addressing various security threats.

What Does People-to-People Exchange Mean for China-US Relations?

Phoenix: There is still some debate in the United States about whether a “Cold War” exists between China and the United States. Some argue that a “Cold War” is already a clear reality, while others believe that interdependence precludes such a situation. Joseph Nye believes that China and the United States are in a state of “cooperative rivalry” rather than a “Cold War.” What is your opinion?

Henry Huiyao Wang: The concept of a new Cold War is subject to differing opinions, and it’s noteworthy that in the United States, there was even a book launch event discussing the Cold War narrative. Some attendees at the event questioned this narrative, noting that today’s era is fundamentally different from the Soviet era. Unlike that time, there are now extensive people-to-people, trade, and investment exchanges between countries, as well as online interactions through the internet, information, and the digital economy. The level of exchange today far surpasses that of the Soviet period.

In my opinion, the notion of a new Cold War is incorrect. While there may be a Cold War mindset and actions reminiscent of the Cold War, achieving a true Cold War state is very difficult in reality. Therefore, it is necessary to oppose the Cold War narrative and strengthen people-to-people exchanges and interactions. For instance, CCG recently hosted students from Sidwell Friends School in Washington, DC. Opening-up tourism and relaxing immigration requirements by giving visa-free travel for US citizens are also necessary. These means can uncover elements to build a community with a shared future for all, identify commonalities among people, and focus on the security of all of humanity rather than just national security.

Phoenix: Some former military personnel and experts in the United States have made many comments on security issues in the Taiwan Strait and the South China Sea. How do you view their perspectives? What are their stereotypes, or are there any positive signals?

Henry Huiyao Wang: That's a great question. This morning, we attended three sessions where Charles Q. Brown Jr., US Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, Antony Blinken, US Secretary of State, and Jake Sullivan, National Security Advisor of the United States, were present to interpret US policies.

I can sense that there has been some policy shift during this administration over the past three and a half years. When the administration first came into office, US officials, such as those in Alaska, were talking about confronting China if necessary. However, this morning, Sullivan said that conflict across the Taiwan Strait must be avoided at all costs, and that such a conflict would be a disaster for the entire world. This indicates a positive shift in the US stance, as they are now aiming to avoid conflict.

Of course, the United States still hopes to restrict China through policies like the "small yard, high fence" concept and there are many incorrect judgments or statements about China regarding the Ukraine crisis. However, after the San Francisco summit, the frequency of high-level US officials visiting China has increased. For example, this morning, Blinken mentioned that Yellen, Raimondo, and himself have all visited China, and Sullivan also frequently communicates with Chinese officials. Their voices tend to be more rational and objective, reflecting the necessity of high-level dialogue and communication between China and the United States.

This morning, three senators and some officials also mentioned that the United States needs to strengthen cognitive warfare, including support for Voice of America, and so on. Government officials, due to their frequent visits to China, are more cautious about their statements and emphasize the need to avoid conflict. I believe this is an improvement compared to the statements made three years ago in Alaska.

After the meeting between President Xi and President Biden, China and the United States resumed official military-to-military dialogues and strengthened cooperation and communication on issues like climate change, fentanyl, and artificial intelligence. American officials who frequently visit China often provide positive and constructive evaluations. However, those who have not visited China, such as some members of Congress, tend to have more negative views of the country. I believe it's crucial to engage these congresspeople more and encourage more US legislators to visit China personally. After coming and seeing for themselves, I believe they will have different impressions about China.

So, the relationship between China and the United States relies not only on government efforts but also the exchanges and cooperation among Congress, media, think tanks, business, and other sectors. This is very necessary and urgent.

Phoenix: I have heard different viewpoints before, suggesting that cultural exchanges have a very slow impact or are hard to break through existing stereotypes. How do you view the role of people-to-people exchanges?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I think maintaining dialogue and communication is extremely important. For example, at this conference, I didn't see any Russians. There are two Chinese participants, but not many. I believe it's essential to keep communication channels open. I mentioned to Jake Sullivan that we hosted students from Sidwell Friends and he said that it's a very prestigious school attended by the children of many officials. He was quite interested in such exchanges, so it is crucial to continue these interactions. Of course, the process of exchange should aim to achieve the purpose of communication.

Both Trump and J.D. Vance spoke at the Republican National Convention, and I noticed that Vance's remarks about China were very negative. There seems to be political correctness emerging where being anti-China could lead to nominations, more attention, and a perception of being tougher, which is very detrimental. I believe it's crucial to expand exchanges, increase visits, and enhance dialogue and communication at all levels. Maintaining contact is very important.

How Should China Respond to the Many Variables in the US Election?

Phoenix: In light of the numerous uncertainties in this year's US election, including the assassination attempt on Trump, Biden's COVID-19 diagnosis, and Vance's strong nationalist stance, how should China respond to these uncertainties?

Henry Huiyao Wang: The US election reflects its political complexity, and the challenges faced by American democracy. From China's perspective, it does not interfere in the US election, but it should be well-prepared. Regardless of who is in power next, China should stick to its principles, which means adhering to reform and opening-up, following the spirit of the Third Plenum, and maintaining dialogue and communication, thus occupying a moral high ground through external openness.

Moreover, China can also strengthen communication and exchanges, such as increasing interactions with various political parties. Trump said that if he wins the presidential election, he will end the Russia-Ukraine war before taking office, and Vance has also mentioned the need to end the Russia-Ukraine war.

China can be the backbone and a decisive force in resolving the war in Ukraine and the conflict in the Middle East. Regardless of who becomes the next US president, they will face the task of addressing regional conflicts and bringing peace to the world. China can play a significant role in this regard. If the new US president can see China as a balancing force in resolving conflicts such as the war in Ukraine and the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, or the North Korea issue, it would help ease China-US relations and highlight China as a leading force in promoting peace.

China and the United States can enhance mutual trust and cooperation through these methods to dispel the so-called "China threat theory." As a peace-loving country, China can offer new opportunities for global governance and find ways to cooperate in a multipolar world, which is also a problem the United States hopes to address.

Phoenix: Thank you, Dr. Wang. It is indeed a very good perspective to have the United States and China work together.

Understanding China's Unique System Through Dialogue and Exchange⁸

On April 20, 2024, the Center for China and Globalization (CCG) and the Bled Strategic Forum (BSF) co-hosted a roundtable that featured Tanja Fajon, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign and European Affairs of Slovenia, discussing China's relations with Slovenia, the US, India, and other nations. During the event, Henry Huiyao Wang, President of CCG, was interviewed by *Delo*, Slovenia's largest newspaper.

A Chinese Perspective on Today's World

Delo: In mid-April, a Slovenian delegation made a final working stop in China at the offices of the Center for China and Globalization (CCG), which included Slovenian Foreign Minister Tanja Fajon as well as several ambassadors and diplomats. The central topic of the roundtable was climate change hosted by Dr. Henry Huiyao Wang, Founder and President of CCG, former counselor of China's State Council and one of the guests of last year's strategic forum in Bled.

So, Dr. Wang, to start off, I'm curious to hear what role you think Slovenia can play in today's world, at least from the Chinese point of view?

Henry Huiyao Wang: It is good that the Slovenian foreign minister visited China and that we're able to talk at such roundtables. Slovenia is a member of the United Nations Security Council, so it is important to seek consensus. This time, the focus was on climate change, which also burdens small countries, as we saw last year with the floods in Slovenia.

Despite its small size, Slovenia can be an important country. As a member of the European Union, it can take the initiative in cooperation with China. It is true that China is a huge country, but now we have many opportunities for cooperation, since both countries are in the UN Security Council. The strategic forum in Bled also has great importance. I've seen with my own eyes how many important people come to Bled, from ministers, prime ministers, and presidents. But we could expand the forum and invite even more Chinese speakers so that your people can also hear who we are.

Delo: Is Slovenia an independent unit for you? Or just a small part that does not differ in any way from the politics of the EU and the collective West?

Henry Huiyao Wang: We know very well that you are in the European Union, but at the same time you are also part of Central and Eastern Europe. I would not classify you as a traditional Western country. Slovenia could have a neutral stance. You could even help to improve China-US relations. Donald Trump will probably be the American President again and his wife is from Slovenia.

If you have the will, you can become a link between China and the European Union, between China and Central Europe, and also between China and the United

⁸ This is the English translation of Henry Huiyao Wang's featured interview in *Delo*.

States. You can also become part of the new Silk Road. You can be China's partner, but still part of Europe. None of this should be excluded.

Delo: Do you feel that we don't respect China enough in Europe and the US?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Partly, for sure. Just look at how few people from Europe come to China. The head of the Bled Strategic Forum, Peter Grk, was in China for the first time, and he saw a China much different than he had imagined.

I think that it is only beneficial for Slovenia if it has good relations with everyone. We already participated together in the 14 + 1 group (cooperation between China and the countries of Central and Eastern Europe). The pandemic and the war in Ukraine put everything on hold, but it would be useful to revive cooperation again. It was a good project, because the focus was on economic integration and not geopolitical bargaining.

Delo: This time at the round table you talked about climate change, but for several years we have been divided by the war in Ukraine and now also with Israel's destruction of Gaza.

Henry Huiyao Wang: In such a divided world, Slovenia has a unique opportunity to become an important country, as you are part of the UN Security Council. You can do a lot to solve the crises in Ukraine and Gaza. You can organize roundtables and conferences, so that as many people as possible are working toward peace.

Delo: But how can we come to concrete solutions, instead of just talking about peace, which in practice never exists?

Henry Huiyao Wang: The Bled Strategic Forum can become a forum for world peace. Invite everyone there: representatives of Ukraine, Russia, Israel, Palestine, USA, and China. No one is talking now, but to end the war, people need to sit down at the table.

China had already proposed holding an emergency summit on peace in Gaza, but the United States vetoed it. Slovenia could make the same proposal. We should have more concrete proposals to end the war in Ukraine and Gaza. I was at the forum in Davos. We talked about Ukraine, but there were no Russian representatives. You need both at the table, otherwise there is no point. The place of negotiations could also be Ljubljana. When we talk about negotiations, we could all do a lot more.

Delo: Is it really not possible to stop Israel's destruction of Gaza with concrete actions? Is the rest of the world completely powerless against the Israel-US alliance?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I have no other answer than to say once again that we need more talks and peace proposals. In the USA they know that they have no moral basis to defend Israel. They can't veto forever, so we need as many peace proposals as possible, because with each new veto, the United States will be more embarrassed. We should put even more pressure on them, which is an opportunity for both Slovenia and China to help end the wars in Gaza and Ukraine by participating in the Security Council.

When the war in Ukraine started, I wrote an open letter to the *New York Times*. I called for an immediate meeting of the seven participants—five permanent members of the Security Council, the European Union, and Ukraine. But nothing happened. Neither meeting nor negotiations.

Delo: Here in China, I have already heard that any war involving USA is only good for China.

Henry Huiyao Wang: It's not true. China is the number one trading partner for more than 120 countries, including Iran, Saudi Arabia, Russia, Ukraine, and is the second most important partner for Israel. When the Houthis started attacking ships in the Red Sea because of Gaza, it was China that lost the most, because Chinese cargo ships pass through that area. China does not want any war. We want more peace and stability. The United States is significantly more obsessed with war than we are. They are involved in the war in Ukraine and Gaza, but they still have time for new sanctions against China. This is not a good sign.

The world is becoming bipolar. Countries are forced to choose who they support. But it is not good for anybody if you are forced to choose between the United States and China, especially since China is a completely different country than people imagine. But you can cooperate with us on different levels. Of course, China is also not perfect and has many problems, but if we talk, we will surely find a way to cooperate.

Delo: What Chinese problems are you referring to?

Henry Huiyao Wang: We had a three-year shutdown due to the pandemic and the economy is recovering more slowly than expected. We also have demographic problems due to the aging of the population. Due to American sanctions, our relationship with the EU is also strained, but part of the blame for bad relations lies also in China, as we are not good at showing the world who we are and what we want. Too few people in China speak English, so we cannot explain to foreigners what is really happening here and how we live.

Our political system is different. One party governs the country, so we have more stability and a five-year plan is based on previous five-year plans. For us, this is a great advantage, but for people from the outside it is a huge mistake. They say we have an autocracy and not a democracy. Instead of having a conversation, we immediately start putting each other into predetermined categories, which doesn't help anyone. So China should definitely do more to portray itself better. More Chinese people should travel the world and more people should come to China. The move to provide visa-free travel for some European countries is a step in the right direction. I don't know what the policy is for Slovenia. Do you still need a visa to visit China?

Delo: Yes, we still need one.

Henry Huiyao Wang: This should be fixed. I don't know why the Chinese prime minister didn't include Slovenia on the list. My proposal is that all EU citizens should have free entry to China, so that they can see what is happening here and who we are. That things here are in order and that the system works. But we can also do more to improve the internet for foreigners, because now you need a VPN.

Delo: You mentioned the aging of the population. Will China need to open its doors to foreign workers to maintain labor efficiency?

Henry Huiyao Wang: We have reached a crucial point where China's population will shrink, but we still have 12 million graduates every year. We are shifting from the most populous society to the most talented. Although China's population is shrinking, the quality of the population is better than ever. In China, we have almost 250 million people with a bachelor's degree. And every year we will have more.

As we have more and more automation and artificial intelligence, we can easily deal with the problem of an aging population. And even though our population is shrinking, it will be a long time before we will be just one billion. But even with a billion people, we will still be a huge country. Japan still has a significantly older population, so they attract foreign workers, which China also can do, but right now we're only focused on attracting foreign talents. We can take care of everything else ourselves.

Delo: In terms of population, you have been overtaken by your neighbor India, with which you do not have very good relations.

Henry Huiyao Wang: The problem is primarily the relationship between the United States and China, so all countries must decide who they support. The US supports India, but China and India should also find a common path. They are the largest countries in the world by population and neighbors, which are the reasons why they should cooperate, especially since they are both members of BRICS.

Looking far back, India and China have always been friends. We also took Buddhism from India. The first Chinese person to "study abroad" was the monk Faxian at the beginning of the fifth century. He went to India and brought many useful things back to China.

We've had ups and downs only for the last fifty or sixty years, but still we've never had a major war. Despite all the disagreements, we can cooperate economically and complement each other. India had a higher GDP than China in the 1980s, but now China has five times the GDP of India, so we have a lot to offer in many areas, from construction, entrepreneurship, and modern technologies. China established the Asian Investment and Infrastructure Bank, and it is India that receives most of its loans, and the bank's vice president is also from India.

There are many opportunities in our relationship. All our problems are political, but also in geopolitical relations we can see that India does not always follow American dictates, for example, in the war in Ukraine.

Delo: But isn't it the case that India needs Russia precisely to balance its relationship with China? Because if it stands up against Russia, India would become significantly more dependent on China. This also raises the question of how much the peace is really a value and how much is just something to trade between great powers.

Henry Huiyao Wang: I will answer a little differently. When it comes to peace, China has a different approach than the US. We are looking for economic cooperation, while the Americans are looking for geopolitical cooperation. The United States has

the Camp David Principles with Japan and South Korea, then there is the Quad association with India, Australia, and Japan, let's not forget the Five Eyes program with Australia, Canada, New Zealand, and Great Britain, and the ever-expanding NATO alliance.

The United States is expanding its political security umbrella, and China is offering economic cooperation to its partners. Such an association is BRICS, and we recently increased the number of members from five to ten. We have invested one trillion US dollars in the New Silk Road for a total of three thousand projects in the Global South. We are also involved in the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership with fifteen Pacific countries, including Japan, South Korea, Australia, and New Zealand. We also have the China-Africa summit and cooperation with Latin America and the Gulf countries. These are all economic unions. In the long run, people will see the difference, so more and more countries will look for cooperation with China, which we already see with BRICS, because Türkiye also wants to join.

Because who wants to fight anyway? Well, Russia is fighting in Ukraine, but it always takes two to make a war. If NATO had not encroached on the Russian border, the Russians might not have fought. Of course, the Russian invasion is a completely wrong move, but it did not happen by accident. There were many events that led to today's war. That's why I think the only way to peace is economic cooperation. It was China that intervened in the restoration of relations between Iran and Saudi Arabia. We were able to do this because we are the largest trading partner with both countries. Instead of building military bases around the world, we prefer to build economic integration and investments.

Our strength is in the economy, and I think that's right. If you increase investments for the military, it means that you invest less money in education, health, and care for the elderly. If we increase economic cooperation, we all make progress, and people who have a better life don't want to fight with guns.

Delo: But China is also investing more in its military. And even here in China we can hear more and more possibilities about military intervention in Taiwan, especially in the case of further interference by the USA.

Henry Huiyao Wang: Former Taiwanese President Ma Ying-jeou recently visited Beijing and met with Chinese President Xi Jinping. Taiwan is a completely different case than Ukraine, because Taiwan and mainland China are one people. We are all Han, so we share the same language and culture.

In the last elections, the Kuomintang and the Taiwan People's Party, which are in favor of unification with mainland China, won a majority. It is true that the Democratic Progressive Party, which advocates secession, won with 40 percent, but even in this party they see that there is no future in secession.

The Chinese government has long emphasized that Taiwan's return does not mean China will burden the island with new taxes. In Hong Kong, we can see how the "one country, two systems" principle works. At most, they will lose an independent foreign policy, but even now there are not many countries that have formal diplomatic relations with Taiwan. Therefore, if there is no foreign interference, Taiwan will merge with mainland China completely naturally.

Delo: Would Taiwan then be allowed to keep its system with more freedom?

Henry Huiyao Wang: Yes, because China keeps saying—one country, two systems. What applies to Hong Kong could easily apply to Taiwan as well.

Delo: But it is precisely the case of Hong Kong that confirms that China's dominance is increasing. And probably the relationship between China and Hong Kong is followed most closely in Taiwan.

Henry Huiyao Wang: There is a lot of talk about Hong Kong, but it has been 25 years since unification. They have passed some new laws, but it is still one country, two systems. People in Hong Kong have a lot of freedom. There's also a lot of talk about political freedom, but next to Hong Kong is a huge China with a unified and strong government that doesn't like that people in Hong Kong are encouraged from to rebel against China by people from abroad.

Taiwan could maintain a different system and special benefits. I don't know why Taiwan would want secession and wars. China does not want war, which won't happen if there is no foreign interference and Taiwan doesn't declare independence. We want peace in China. We have only had an economic revival for twenty years, while in Europe and the United States have had it for a hundred years, so the Chinese people do not want to destroy this good life, which we've just started to enjoy.

Delo: Can the current status quo persist?

Henry Huiyao Wang: It's quite possible. If the Americans do not send weapons and if American congressmen do not visit Taiwan, we will most likely continue to maintain the current status quo.

Delo: But wouldn't it be right for the people of Taiwan to have the final say? Because now we're just listening to what China and the United States think about Taiwan.

Henry Huiyao Wang: We are listening to Taiwan. I have already said that in the last elections the two parties that support unification with mainland China won the majority. There are 60 percent of such people. Lai Ching-te, chairman of the Democratic Progressive Party, which supports independence is also talking less and less about secession.

With all the disagreements and competition between the United States and China, we often overlook the fact that there are a huge number of American companies doing business in China, as well as a significant number of Chinese expatriates in the US. So the relationship is not so black and white.

Delo: True. Disagreements are introduced by politicians, especially the American one. The rich in the United States are only getting richer, so social disparities are getting bigger and bigger. Wall Street has record business, and so do American multinationals, but little of that money goes back to the American people to solve social problems. Let's not forget that China also holds a significant portion of the US foreign debt.

Henry Huiyao Wang: China perfectly fits the US profile of an enemy: we are a big country, economically, we will overtake the United States soon and we have a different political system. American opposition to China is therefore primarily political. In the end, it is easiest for American politicians to say that people in the United States are losing their jobs because of China, and we always become an especially big enemy in an American election year.

But China continues to reiterate that it wants cooperation, risk reduction, and win-win integration. Unfortunately, in the United States, there is still a lot of prejudice against China, so it will be difficult to resolve disagreements in the short term, even if they would only benefit China. For example, China invests a lot in the development of solar panels, and electric cars; maybe the United States will realize one day that we are not really the problem. There is nothing wrong with having economic growth and a different political system and it's not the end of the world if it stays that way. Because we can live in peace. But it is also true that there is always friction when a new power begins to approach the main global power.

Delo: How important are the US elections for China? Who would you rather see in the position of American president?

Henry Huiyao Wang: It will be about the same with anyone. Joe Biden is more predictable. He uses the carrot and stick method, so he is sometimes harsh, sometimes kind. Donald Trump has many faces, so you never know what awaits you, but above all, he is a man who always wants to make a deal. And if he wants business, China is the best country. We have a lot to offer, so we can do business with everyone who wants it.

We're not really too worried about who the American president will be. American politics is pretty much the same all the time—only the face changes. I expect that China will continue to be a major US target, regardless of who is president. But as I've said, there are differences. Trump is looking for business, Biden is looking for political stability.

China will also remain the same. We don't colonize anyone, we don't send military troops anywhere, we don't attack anyone. You don't have to worry about us. We may have nuclear weapons, but we will never use them first. We do not threaten like Russia, which says that it will use nuclear weapons if there are problems on the battlefield. We became the largest trading nation because we are interested in business, not warfare.

Delo: How big of a problem is it for the global community that we lack world leaders who are more committed to a just and true peace? Looking at the upcoming US elections, neither Biden nor Trump inspires excessive hope.

Henry Huiyao Wang: Biden is the oldest American presidential candidate in history, only slightly younger is Trump. I think it is not healthy that a country with so many talented people has such candidates in the elections, just look at how weak the debates are in American elections about China as an autocracy and democracy in the West. The United States is not exactly a model of democracy if it cannot offer better and younger presidential candidates.

Delo: What is the situation in China's political hinterland? Do you have fresh candidates for leading the country in the future?

Henry Huiyao Wang: President Xi Jinping is by no means so old that he needs to be replaced.

Delo: But at 70, he's not exactly young.

Henry Huiyao Wang: But he's not old. In Chinese tradition, we believe that leaders should be older people. We have always strived for stability and a strong leader. With such a large nation, stability is of the utmost importance. If we had a new government every few years, we would never have made this kind of progress. We have a five-year plan, which is an upgrade of the previous five-year plan, so the government has to follow the guidelines, and targets.

We should not judge anyone by how long someone has been president, but by how well and stably he leads the country. Singapore's Prime Minister Lee Hsien Loong has led the country since 2004 and Angela Merkel was chancellor for 16 years, Vladimir Putin has been the head of Russia for more than twenty years. Under the leadership of Xi Jinping, China doubled its GDP and lifted hundreds of millions of people out of poverty. In terms of economic achievements, he is an excellent president.

People should come here and see what I'm talking about. Leading a country of 1.4 billion people is not easy. Nevertheless, there are no shooting attacks like in the USA, nor are there terrorist attacks like in Russia. You never hear about 50 getting shot in China. Our streets are very safe. We used to have pickpockets, but now they are gone.

Delo: However, no one is allowed to criticize the Chinese government in public.

Henry Huiyao Wang: Our way of governing is different. We have been a meritocracy for thousands of years and it is no different now. Politicians have to start their careers in the local environment, then they can work their way up to leading positions in the province and only at the end they can think about the national government. No one can come to an important government position with just one or two nice public appearances.

Our arrangement could also be described as a technological democracy. We all use our phones in China and vote with them every day—what we eat, where we travel, what we buy. All these are our elections when we vote with our wallets. The government has a lot of data about people through mobile applications, for example, through WeChat so it knows exactly what they want.

China has always been part of global democracy. Our biggest opposition is the USA, the European Union, and Japan. Everyone criticizes us, so no one can say that China lacks critics. There are also eight non-communist parties in China. They make suggestions and criticisms to the government, but not publicly through the media.

It doesn't matter if cat is white or black as long as it catches mice. With the current government, China has become the world's second-largest economy. We obviously did something right. Why would we copy the United States and the EU when we have our own system based on Chinese traditions and values?

Restoration of the *Gaokao*, Studying Abroad and Cross-Cultural Career Development—Henry Huiyao Wang’s Story of Personal Growth⁹

Living History: Stories from the Opening of China is an ongoing documentary series of video interviews about the period between the opening of China in 1979 and the 2010 Shanghai Expo. The program team has the goal of recording and preserving the personal experiences of academics, diplomats, policymakers, businesspeople, artists, students, athletes, and others who lived through this period, relating the surprises, challenges and memorable experiences people made together. It’s personal stories through which history comes alive.

This period of recent Chinese history is too rarely discussed and runs the danger of being forgotten if we miss the chance to preserve the memories from this time of opening and cooperation. *Living History* aims to create a personal and intriguing record of this critical period in China and produce a thoughtful, well-researched, and accurate long-form documentary interview series that is appealing to curious people around the world. An independent and not-for-profit project, the program is supported by a grant from the United States Consulate in Shanghai. As of May 2024, the team had completed filming more than twenty interviews for this series.

Episode 8 is an interview with Henry Huiyao Wang, Founder and President of the Center for China and Globalization (CCG) and one of the first students from the Chinese mainland to obtain an MBA in North America. This is an interview of his incredible personal journey.

Living History: Today, we’re speaking with Dr. Henry Huiyao Wang, the Founder and President of the Center for China and Globalization (CCG), a top think tank in Beijing. Dr. Wang is a leading expert on topics such as China and globalization, global trade and investment, and international relations, with a focus on the US-China relationship and global migration. That’s something he got early experience with, after pursuing his bachelor’s degree in Guangdong in 1982, he moved first to Canada and then to England for his MBA and PhD studies before becoming a senior fellow at the Harvard Kennedy School and a visiting fellow at the Brookings Institution. Back in China, he taught at Peking University and Tsinghua University, and he was a counselor to the State Council of China—China’s Cabinet. We’re very pleased to speak with him today.

Dr. Henry Huiyao Wang, welcome!

Henry Huiyao Wang: Thank you, I’m very pleased to talk to you.

Living History: I just learned something I didn’t know before: you started learning English by reading books in a little shed with a bare light bulb in Sichuan. It was there that you learned that there was a world outside of China. How did you imagine that world to be before you got to travel abroad?

⁹ This transcript is produced based on the video and hasn’t been reviewed by the two speakers.

Henry Huiyao Wang: When I was a student, we were thirsty for knowledge. There's a saying in Chinese: you have to read 10,000 books and travel 10,000 miles. At that time, if you only read books, for example, you learn English and you read stories of famous people in China and the outside world, you still feel that you are not in touch with them. You really have to see the world.

Very early on, my father went to foreign countries. He worked in Africa on the Tanzania-Zambia Railway. My mother's family was also very strong in terms of supporting education. I remember my mom bought me a very expensive Chinese-English dictionary when I was in elementary school. It was great to see the world, not only from the books, but also when I could go abroad.

I think my family education and reading books sowed the seeds of the idea that someday I would have to go and see the world. That affected my life. I have traveled to almost 100 countries and many regions, and I spent over a decade outside China, which was an enormous opportunity for me and opened the door for me to see the world. Bringing the world closer to China and China closer to the world has become part of my mission and that's why I founded the Center for China and Globalization.

Living History: All of that would have been impossible had Deng Xiaoping not reinstated the "*gaokao*"—China's National College Entrance Examination.

Henry Huiyao Wang: That was a very important part of my life, of course. Without Deng Xiaoping, we don't know!

Living History: Take me back to that day. Describe to me how it started. I believe there was something you heard on the radio.

Henry Huiyao Wang: Yeah, absolutely. After high school—I'd only finished my second year of high school when we were sent down to the countryside. At only 17 or 18 in the countryside, there was no future because the slogan at that time was "With one red heart, settle down in the countryside for life." We felt hopeless at that time, because we didn't know how our lives would end.

In the countryside, we worked very hard. I had to work from 6 o'clock in the morning when the production brigade leader called me to go out to the field, until 11 am before the sun got too hot. Then I came back, cooked my own lunch, which was normally porridge and other very simple food before going back to work at 3 o'clock until 10 o'clock in the evening because it was not as hot. It was very hard. After toiling in the fields the whole day, we made about 20 cents a day in RMB in the 1970s, which was only 70% of what a normal farmer could earn. They got 25 cents a day, and I got 20 cents a day.

That was a very hard life, but I never gave up, which was something very important and I continued to study. But it was a very difficult life. First of all, in the countryside, you were always hungry because there was not enough food to eat. And they only gave you a quarter kilo of lamp oil that you could use for your light, so you couldn't make the lamp too bright. You had to keep the flame very small and it only produced a little light. That's how we had to study.

I never gave up, though. I listened to the radio a lot. And this was already after Nixon visited China, so they resumed English lessons on the radio. I also read the

books I brought from the cities. I also subscribed to a newspaper which I had to walk about two or three miles every day to pick up to read.

That really got me into this studying habit because I believed that the trend around the world was to shrink the rural population and move to cities. I thought, “Why is China doing the opposite, making people go from urban cities to the countryside? It should be the other way around.” This gave me the confidence that this was not going to be forever and that someday things would change. And that day did come—in October 1977. At that time we had no television and the only way to get information was over a loudspeaker in the village. I lived in a very shabby, old, and very cold, small hut on the farm and I heard the news over the loudspeaker announced that China was going to restore the university entrance exams in December of that year.

It was really a big surprise and I was very happy because I knew that all the studying I had been doing would finally pay off. Initially, I wanted to study engineering, but I’d lost all my math knowledge because it had been so long. So I turned to the social sciences and brushed up on my Chinese language, history, culture, and, of course, English, too. And I applied for the English exam and studied.

That was the first year they resumed the entrance exams and there were about 5.6 million Chinese students that hadn’t been able to take the test during the decade-long Cultural Revolution since all the universities were shut down during that decade. This meant that 5.6 million people were eligible to take the exam, but there were only about 200,000 spots, so only about 4%; a very small percentage of people would have the chance to get in. I was one of them. It was the Class of ’77, but we actually began in the spring of 1978, because the exams had been in December and we didn’t get our acceptance letters until February and would start school in March. But that totally changed my life. Without that experience, none of my other stories would have happened.

This was all because of Deng Xiaoping, and I have a story about him. He became Vice Premier in 1977, but he wasn’t the top leader yet. The first thing he did was to restore the university exam, but there were people against him that said, “This is what Mao decided. You cannot change that.” Deng Xiaoping said, “Why not?” Then they said, “OK. But there’s not enough time. We already passed the spring deadline to send out notices. We will miss this year.” Deng Xiaoping said, “No, we’ll still do it, even if it’s in December or the end of the year, we still have to do it in 1977. We cannot postpone this any longer.” Then they said, “Okay, but there’s not enough paper to print so many examination papers.” Deng said, “Let’s use the paper for Chairman Mao’s works to print the examination papers.”

He was a visionary and very decisive. I think he probably saved one or even two generations of Chinese people and he paved the way for China’s opening-up and reform. That happened in 1977, 47 years ago, and a whole generation grew out of that, which has changed China today. That was the first decision he made.

The second decision he made was to allow Chinese students to go abroad, which wasn’t allowed during the Cultural Revolution. Somebody even told him, “look, if you send people overseas, people may not come back.” But then Deng said, “Don’t worry, let’s send them, not just a few hundred, let’s send them in the tens of thousands

or hundreds of thousands. Let's send them. Even if a lot of them don't come back, we're still going to benefit from those that do."

He was very bold in his vision. I think that this can be attributed to his five years in France. I went to the factory where he worked in France. It was very impressive. Deng spent five years outside China studying and working. He was the designer of China's reform and opening-up program, which changed the lives of future generations.

Since then, the number of universities in China has expanded from a few hundred universities to 3,000. The number of Chinese college students has grown from less than a quarter million the year that I got in to 12 million a year. You can see how many times it has grown since then. Deng Xiaoping was visionary and decisive. His reforms began in 1977, only one year after Mao passed away. He had a very liberal way of thinking and he really changed China completely.

Living History: We've spoken with some international students who came to China to study around the same time. I wonder, how was your experience with foreign students? How did you think they adjusted? It must have also been completely new for you as well.

Henry Huiyao Wang: During the early 80's or even late 70's, China was still just getting out of the Cultural Revolution. I mean, people were living a very basic, simple life and things were not modern. At that time, I remember it took me three days to travel from Chengdu, my hometown, to Guangzhou. I had to change trains in Zhengzhou and it was a very long journey. Of course, at that time in China, there were no skyscrapers. I remember the highest building in Guangzhou at that time was one of the hotels that was only 20-some stories. It was already the highest building in the whole city. And there were no taxis or subway. You could only take the bus. And there were no supermarkets. So, the modern life that we are enjoying today was totally missing at that time.

When we went to the university, there was a competition among all the brightest people they recruited during the first two years. At that time, not many foreigners were able to come to China. There were some, but very few. The challenge was that you had to change your way of thinking, from the Cultural Revolution to a new era of reform, liberating your mind and liberalizing your thoughts. That was the movement at that time. We also talked about philosophy and the meaning of life.

We witnessed so many changes in China. In 1979, they opened the special economic zone in Shenzhen and we actually went to Shenzhen. It was a village at that time, but later it became a massive construction site. The Shenzhen International Trade Center was built in three days on one floor, which we started to call "Shenzhen speed." It was very interesting because there were lots of changes and a lot of difficulties, but also a lot of hope. China embarked on opening-up and reform and a lot of people were liberated from the Cultural Revolution. A lot of people were cleared of so-called "crimes" that they were convicted of during that period. Society became quite open at that time. I think that helped China to take off. Then the foreign investment started to come in and the special economic zones were established in 14 coastal cities including Pudong and all over China. That was a very memorable time and a lot of great changes took place. Our generation witnessed all of them.

Living History: I noticed the first sentence in one of your recent books, and it said, “Everything is changing all the time. This is an unavoidable conclusion for anyone who observes the world around them for any length of time.” After Guangzhou, you got to go abroad and compare what you had imagined and learned from books and what it was actually like. Tell me what that was like for you. What your initial impressions were?

Henry Huiyao Wang: After Guangzhou, I was assigned to work in the Ministry of Foreign Trade and Economic Cooperation in Beijing for two and a half years. Before I applied to study overseas, there was a professor I met from NYU who told me there was an MBA major in North America that could be very useful because it taught management, marketing, accounting, and human resources. I was really intrigued by such a multidisciplinary major and I applied for some scholarships. I ended up going to Canada as my first destination.

In 1984, I had to travel from Beijing to Shanghai, Shanghai to Tokyo, Tokyo to San Francisco, and then to New York and then to Toronto. After two and a half years working in the Ministry, it was an absolute culture shock. There was so much traffic and flying over New York you saw an ocean of lights. On the highway there were as many cars as there were bicycles in China and they went so fast. I’d never seen that before. Then you had supermarkets with so much food, which we didn’t have in China at that time. It was a big culture shock to see such an affluent society and how big of a gap there was between China and the outside world, particularly the Western world, and how there was still a lot of room to improve.

The culture shock was one thing, but Western society was also different. You had to be more independent. I had to open a bank account and see the doctor by myself. I had to shop on my own. I had no family or parents to rely on, and I didn’t have much of a social network. Fortunately, when we got to the university, we had very good faculty members and different student clubs, which were very friendly and helpful. There were also students from different countries that were all very friendly, so that was surprising to see. It seemed that there were a lot of volunteers who wanted to help and I was quite impressed with that. We also went to church. We also listened to different speakers and attended many social events. Those were really good experiences.

The only thing we couldn’t get used to was that it took so long to get a letter from China. It took 20 to 25 days, if you wrote a letter today, you wouldn’t get a reply until the next month. If you wanted to get two replies, you had to write two letters in a month so that you could get one in two weeks. And then of course, making a phone call cost you dozens of US dollars, which was an astronomical number at that time for a poor student.

There were many things we had to cope with, but I generally was coping fine. I used to live in an apartment under a bridge, which was very noisy, but I felt it was a good experience to experience local life. Student life was very enriching and changed my life. It also gave me full exposure to local thinking and the minds of different students from different countries. It was a very good experience.

Living History: How did you benefit from studying overseas? Specifically, how was going to a Western university at that time different for you?

Henry Huiyao Wang: I think one of the things I learned when I was studying in Canada and later in the UK, and Harvard, as well as the very open learning environment. In China, everything was about the examination, specifically a written examination. There was very little chance for talking. There was no classroom participation, debate, or presentation. We had to get used to that. That was very common in Western universities. I think now China is starting to adopt those techniques, but at that time, in the 80's, coming from a Chinese university, we were basically just memorizing, taking notes, and doing assignments and examinations, whereas, in Western universities, they gave you big papers that you had to hand in 24h or 48h later. Further your classroom participation and speaking counted for a quarter of your grade. All of that was fairly new.

I think I benefited a lot from the critical thinking too. There's more individualism and you had to thinked loudly and analyze things in different ways. There was no correctness. Basically, you had to prove to yourself that what you said or what you analyzed was correct and logically sound. That was a good exercise and I think I benefited a lot from that.

Going to different countries, seeing different cultures, different ideologies, and different thinking gives you a better perspective on where you originally come from and your original thoughts and upbringing. That gives you a really global mind. I found that studying abroad or working abroad could really give you a global mindset, enabling you to become more objective, not narrow-minded or one-sided. It really helped me become a link between China and the outside world because I'd lived overseas and knew what was going on, but we were also from China.

There are more and more people like that now, but in the early 1980s I was one of the very few students who went both pursue an MBA and a PhD program at that time. I also took quite a lot of doctoral courses in management. Actually, I was also one of the first Chinese graduates to get into a multinational. I worked in a big multinational in Montreal in the late 1980s, after which I became the first student from China to be hired in open recruitment by the Quebec government. That was in the early 1990s. All those firsts show how cross-cultural communication and knowledge on both sides can be very useful. I truly benefited a lot from my overseas study experience.

Living History: You previously mentioned that in the 1980s, you also worked for the Chinese government. What was that like?

Henry Huiyao Wang: It was a very memorable experience when I first joined the Chinese government. I was one of the few as they picked the brightest from the university. Two of us were assigned to the Ministry of Commerce, which was then known as the Ministry of Foreign Trade and Economic Cooperation. The other one, my classmate, later became a Vice Minister of Commerce and Vice Minister of Foreign Affairs. We were assigned to the Ministry at the same time.

What I found very interesting was that when I got into the Ministry there were so many talented people. Everybody was a college graduate and knew a foreign

language. But in the beginning we were definitely underutilized. People were saying, “You’re young, you’ve just come, you don’t have experience.” They didn’t give us a lot of important work to do. But even those things could be an opportunity sometimes.

I remember during the early 1980s, China joined the World Bank, which sent experts to Beijing to give seminars on international competitive bidding, international procurement guidelines, and other concepts. But I had already studied them in my spare time because I knew it was useful knowledge, so I already knew a lot of the things they taught when I joined the ministry. I was single and I had lots of time.

It was a week-long seminar and the first day was given to a senior interpreter, but on the second day they said, “Okay, you try.” So I tried it because I thought that was how communication could work: you had to have a lot of background knowledge, know a lot of history, all the technical jargon, and the latest terms, so I applied that to that interpretation process. Immediately, the instructor from the World Bank felt that there was chemistry between him and the audience, because they could now ask the right questions because of my interpretation.

After that, I did all the interpretation for the next five days, which gave me experience and confidence. If you are really prepared, willing to study the other side, have enough knowledge, and understand their language and their culture, then you can communicate. Understanding each other is not just understanding language itself. It requires a lot of background knowledge and a lot of technical knowledge.

In the 80’s, it wasn’t just the World Bank. We talked with many other visiting government officials, which was great, but I realized there was a lack of understanding on both sides. The challenge was really that we could not put ourselves into each other’s shoes. We were just talking from our own position, and that sometimes could be difficult.

The best way is really to think from the other side and vice versa. It helps a lot. But you have to have the people who have knowledge of the other side or who have spent time in foreign countries and spent time in China, especially if they know the language and have the technical background behind it. Otherwise, it will be very difficult to communicate. That’s my experience.

Living History: You wrote, “In 1984, to pursue an MBA when few at the time in China even knew what an MBA was...” What an extraordinary decision! What did your parents say?

Henry Huiyao Wang: It was really a big decision for me, but that was always what I wanted because I learned a foreign language, about foreign trade, and all those things. Also, after two and a half years of working in the Ministry, I found myself needing to have an upgrade. At that time, there were opportunities to be assigned to work in the different embassies of China, but I preferred to study. So I applied a few times and then finally took an exam and got a scholarship. I jumped on the opportunity because I thought some vision could help. I knew that my parents, my father actually, worked overseas and he told me it was important to go overseas.

Of course, at that time, China just opened up, and you had to learn everything from overseas. So even though going overseas was unknown, it was important that

you go and experience it. You know, you have to read 10,000 books and travel 10,000 miles. And that's my motto.

When I studied all those historical figures, Deng Xiaoping, Zhou Enlai, or the scientists or social scholars, a lot of them who made a great contribution to China were overseas students. That was a good example for me. That really encouraged me to go and I never hesitated. I applied, I knew I could miss the opportunity at that time to work in the Ministry, but I thought probably it was more important for me to get this more advanced knowledge and advanced preparation for my future work and jobs. That was why I made that decision and it also was the right decision.

I would still advise people to go and study. My think tank has been publishing reports on Chinese students studying abroad for the last fifteen years. Since the 1980s, there have been about 10 million Chinese students studying abroad, including Hong Kong, Macau, and everybody. That's a huge chunk of talent. Of course, a lot stayed overseas, but then the global talent circulation and the talent return greatly changed China. So I think this study abroad movement initiated by Deng Xiaoping has really made huge changes in China and also benefited millions of people who did that. Of course, I'm one of them.

Living History: And then you eventually decided to come back to China and start your own business. And I have heard from other people that it was a very challenging time, but that there was also this atmosphere of optimism. How do you remember these times?

Henry Huiyao Wang: After my stay in Hong Kong as a chief trade representative of the Quebec government for Hong Kong, China at that time, when I finished that job, Deng Xiaoping was inspecting Shenzhen, his famous 1992 tour. And he said, "If you want to make a greater contribution, it's better to come back to the mainland." So that was a great inspiration for me. After my duties in Hong Kong, I didn't return to Quebec because I felt I was already in Hong Kong and I would like to come back to China.

So at the beginning of 1993, I started to come back. But what to do? That's the thing. I didn't have a second job, but I thought maybe it was time to utilize my experience in business, academics, government, and the public; it was time to start my own company to be an entrepreneur. That was what got me into establishing my company at that time. Of course, there was no office tower in China, in Beijing, so we rented a hotel room where you could sleep and where you could work, but it was also a hard life. For example, because there was a time difference, during the daytime, you were busy. During the evening, there were phone calls coming back from North America, from Europe, from different places because we were doing international business consulting.

I remember it took me half a year to register a foreign representative office in Beijing. I got all the approvals, and I got all the sponsors. You had to talk to different bureaucratic organizations. And finally, we got that. And then I remember it was very expensive to install a telephone. A fixed line cost you 5,000 RMB at that time. Even, to have a fax machine, you needed a Ministry of Post and Telecommunications approval. Also, I bought a computer when I finished my job in Hong Kong. That computer had

been left in customs for several months before I could redeem it because you had to [determine] whether it was going to be tax-exempt or not, or how a computer was classified and what kind of tariffs should apply, all those things—they never had a good example. And then we had to wait for the final decision. Finally, I got it done.

So it was really challenging to establish a business in China in 1993. I remember at that time there was no taxis in China. There was only a very small minivan. You paid 10 yuan and you could travel across Beijing completely. Even that was very expensive. So it was a good experience. But then I think the most important part was really to build the business.

Living History: China joining the WTO must have helped a lot.

Henry Huiyao Wang: China joining the WTO was a monumental landmark for the Chinese opening-up. It took a long time. You know, China spent 15 or 16 years[to join the WTO]. Initially, it was the GATT [General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade], and then later on they changed the name to the WTO and China still wanted to apply for that.

But I would reclassify the Chinese movement of joining the WTO as a mini-revolution in China because you had to abolish so many outdated clauses, you had to change the minds of the people, you had to get people on top of that. I would say it was really a big battle. People were so used to the old style. For example, before China joined the WTO, foreign trade was managed by a few dozen Chinese state-owned companies who monopolized the space. So everybody had to go through the foreign trade company to do foreign trade. There was a license required, there was a quota required. It was such a big headache and bureaucratic tape to go through. But then, since China joined the WTO, they liberalized all those areas, and I just read the news there are about 6 million companies that can do foreign trade. Basically, everybody is an individual. If you want to do it, you're allowed to do it, all the companies. It was incredible. And that's why China became the largest trading nation in the world. And then China's GDP since joining the WTO has gone up twelve or thirteen times already, enormously.

So I think the challenge at that time was really to break through the psychological barrier because people were worried about joining the WTO. For example, people talked about joining the WTO as if the wolf was coming. One of the arguments was that China's automobiles were in the infant stage. If China joined the WTO, they would be wiped out by foreign companies. Foreign automobiles would flood China. China would no longer have a domestic industry of automobiles. And that turned out to be not true because even though more foreign companies were coming, you've got Volkswagen, you've got BMW, Mercedes, everybody, before joining the WTO, there was only one model of a Chinese foreign company, which was Santana. 20 years, one model, never changed. But since China joined the WTO, there has been competition. There were a lot of foreign companies coming and that's also elevated the Chinese auto industry. And then you can see that after 20 years since China joined the WTO, China has now become the largest automobile maker in the world. And last year, China became the largest exporter of automobiles in the world.

So joining the WTO has not only greatly benefited Chinese companies but also enabled China make more contributions to the world. I think the WTO has many advantages: it liberated people's minds and made people more open. It also gave them more experience in testing the waters and being more competitive. Thirdly, it cultivated a lot of Chinese international companies, too.

Furthermore, it is really important that you have all the multinationals come to China, and for the Chinese to go to interact with them. There's not much domestic interaction. China needs to improve as well, like its payment system. Travel assistance in China should be more convenient and maybe China should even open the internet up so you can access Google, Facebook, Twitter, and all those things. I think China should do that as well.

My thinking is that the people-to-people exchange is crucial. It's very important to enhance understanding and it's the bond between the two countries and also the rest of the world. That's why I was encouraged by President Xi. He spoke at the San Francisco summit when he visited the United States and he was saying China would be interested in inviting 50,000 youth from the United States to come to China. So this means each year, 10,000. I hope that the target can be realized and then more people can come.

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About the Center for China and Globalization

Founded in 2008 and headquartered in Beijing, the Center for China and Globalization (CCG) is China's leading global non-governmental think tank. CCG maintains multiple domestic branches and overseas representatives, supported by a seasoned team of full-time researchers and professionals engaged in research on globalization, global governance, the international economy and trade, international relations, and global migration.

CCG is the first and sole non-governmental Chinese think tank to be granted special consultative status with the Economic and Social Council of the United Nations (ECOSOC). In the "2020 Global Go To Think Tank Index" by the University of Pennsylvania Think Tank and Civil Society Program (TTCSP), CCG ranked 64th among top think tanks worldwide and in the top 50 of global independent think tanks. CCG has also been recognized as a "4A non-governmental organization" by Beijing Municipal Government Civil Affairs Department. CCG is also a national Postdoctoral Programme Research Center certified by the Chinese Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security.

CCG has built a research network of leading experts both domestic and abroad and engages in ongoing research on China and globalization. CCG publishes more than 10 books every year in English and Chinese in addition to its research reports. It shares its research findings with the public and has thousands of books and reports, which collectively receive hundreds of thousands visits each year.

CCG is deeply involved in contributing to public policy. It regularly submits policy recommendations to relevant state agencies and ministries, many of which have been incorporated into discussions within China's central leadership organs and have shaped major policy decisions across relevant departments, contributing to ongoing government policymaking and institutional innovation.

About CCG's Publications

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This series is designed to present a wide range of global views on issues related to China and Globalization, opportunities and challenges of China's rise in the world stage and China's roles in global governance, global economy, global development and global security. It outlines China's international relations with major global powers and the rest of the world, and it contains recommendations and proposals for the future of sustainable development, prospects for China's further capital and market liberalization, and China's globalizing trajectories as experienced by the world.

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Author: Huiyao Wang

Publisher: Springer (August 2, 2022)

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This book focuses on globalization and China's evolving role in the world, offering unique perspectives on a remarkable period, which saw the global landscape reshaped by China's continued rise, intensifying great power competition, and a deadly pandemic.

The essays center on three interconnected themes—China's remarkable development under its policy of Reform and Opening-up, China's deepening integration into the global economy and its rise in an increasingly multipolar world, and the quest to reinvigorate global governance and multilateralism to address the pressing global challenges of the 21st century.

These insights are useful for academics, policymakers, students, and anyone trying to deepen their understanding of China's development and role in making globalization work for our multipolar world.

More info: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-981-16-9253-6>

Global Development and Cooperation with China: New Ideas, Policies and Initiatives for a Changing World

Editors: Henry Huiyao Wang and Mabel Lu Miao

Publisher: Springer (April, 2025)

This open access book draws on the insights and wisdom of representatives from a wide range of international organizations with a presence in China, leveraging their rich experience in their respective fields as well as their unique understanding of China's development and its role in the world. In a world of increased tension between governments and a rise in regionalism, globally positioned non-governmental international organizations are key to keeping the lines of communication open. In addition to the United Nations and its affiliate organizations, a host of international organizations are ensuring that the world's most pressing issues, in areas ranging from economics to education, are being discussed.

This new book focuses on the latest trends in four major areas—global governance, trade and economics, science and technology, and culture and exchange—providing the readers with the latest developments in these areas with a special focus on China and its relevant contributions. It is hoped that this book will inspire deeper discussion and consideration of the issues we face as a global community and how non-governmental entities can play a stabilizing role in global communication and in exploring solutions to common challenges.

Free ebook: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-981-96-2452-2>***Enhancing Global Governance in a Fragmented World: Prospects, Issues, and the Role of China***

Editors: Henry Huiyao Wang and Mabel Lu Miao

Publisher: Springer (June, 2024)

This open access book explores the 'polycrisis' currently affecting nearly all nations by exploring key themes such as multilateralism and globalization from the perspective of think tanks from nearly every continent, searching for various solutions to the ills that currently plague the world and a way to create a future in which everyone benefits.

As China's preeminent non-governmental think tank, the Center for China and Globalization (CCG) has invited 30 leading figures from the global think tank community to sift through the myriad layers of multilateralism and global governance and provide a contextual analysis of major themes both from a theoretical and practical perspective, focusing on China in detail, but also examining the world as a whole.

Think tanks are essential in analyzing current trends and providing potential solutions that aid governments, international organizations, and business in finding solutions beneficial to all. As a key source of innovative ideas, they have become even more valuable today as the pace of change accelerates, geopolitical complexity increases, and the world has to deal with global crises that no country can address on its own.

A common, central theme through all of the 25 essays in this book is the need for a more universal, inclusive, and multilateral approach to reforming global governance. It is our hope that the views of the experts from think tanks and other non-governmental organizations in this compilation will provide valuable insights to help heal the gaps in our fragmented world.

Free ebook: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-981-97-2558-8>

The Future of China's Development and Globalization

Editors: Henry Huiyao Wang and Mabel Lu Miao

Publisher: Springer (January 1, 2024)

As the world continues to recover from the fear and uncertainty of the COVID-19 pandemic, a new set of challenges like increased geopolitical tensions and climate change have become increasingly prominent. This open access book, which contains the views of ambassadors to Beijing on topics ranging from bilateral relations to potential cooperation, global development and even more of the most immediate issues, aims to help readers make sense of our changing world and China's role in it.

Building on the success of our previous volume *China and the World in a Changing Context: Perspectives from Ambassadors to China*, the Center for China and Globalization (CCG) has invited 27 ambassadors to examine China's role in this context of constant flux, focusing specifically on China's perspective, including its trade and investment ties with other countries, as well as its role in multilateral regional relations and global governance.

These diplomatic envoys from countries around the world serve as pivotal contact points between nations across a wide range of fields, from economics and culture to health and the environment. Their perspectives, representing both developing and industrialized countries, are both invaluable and illuminating—not only in conveying the views and experiences of their own countries, but also for their insights into global affairs and China's development.

It is our hope that the views expressed in this volume will inspire even more discussion on the next best step to take in finding solutions to the problems we face, and in particular how China can use its own experience and wisdom to better contribute and engage with the world in finding solutions together. This book provides a wealth of perspective and insight that we hope will benefit not only academics and policy-makers, but also the private sector and individuals.

Free ebook: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-981-99-7512-9>

Soft Power and Great-Power Competition: Shifting Sands in the Balance of Power Between the United States and China

Author: Joseph S. Nye, Jr.

Publisher: Springer (April 26, 2023)

This open access book consists of essays selected from Joseph S. Nye, Jr.'s last three decades of writing and illustrates a variety of perspectives on the nature of power, the role of the United States in the world, and US-China relations. Through this

collection, it is hoped that readers will gain a better understanding of today's global environment and find that while great power competition may be inevitable in a world as centers of power shift, cooperating to address transnational challenges can be a positive sum game.

The contents of this book are divided into four main parts. Part One discusses the origins and political progress of the concept of "Soft Power." Part Two explores soft power in the American experience, its sources and interaction with US foreign policy, as well as its ebb and flow in the age of Obama, Trump, and Biden. Part Three examines the rise of and the opportunities and difficulties for Chinese soft power, focusing on China's investment in soft power and how this demonstrates its commitment to a peaceful rise. However, it also addresses the question of how China can get "smart" in how it uses soft power. Part Four provides a bird's-eye view of power shifts in the 21st century and the interactions between the US as an established power and China as a rising power, while also reassuring readers that Thucydidean fears are unnecessary and a Cold War is avoidable. Both countries have to realize that some forms of power must be exercised with others, not over others, and that the development of soft power need not be a zero-sum game. Ultimately, the US-China relationship is a "cooperative rivalry" where a successful strategy of "smart competition" is necessary, and cooperation on transnational challenges like climate change, pandemics, cyberterrorism, and nuclear proliferation will serve to benefit not only China and the US, but the world as a whole.

Free ebook: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-981-99-0714-4>

China and the World in a Changing Context: Perspectives from Ambassadors to China

Editors: Huiyao Wang and Lu Miao

Publisher: Springer (March 5, 2022)

Ambassadors are diplomatic envoys serving as pivotal contact points between nations across a wide range of fields, from economics and culture to health and the environment. The special group of ambassadors in this book—those based in Beijing—are at the forefront of what for many countries is one of their most important bilateral relationships, as well one of the most striking and consequential aspects of global affairs in the 21st century: the rise of China on the world stage.

This book aims to present an overview of China and the world from diverse angles. It brings together essays by ambassadors to China on a range of bilateral and multilateral issues, including trade and investment, regional economic cooperation, sustainable development, technology and innovation, and entrepreneurship. Given their familiarity with China and extensive international experience, the insights of these ambassadors are useful for policymakers, academics, entrepreneurs, students, and anyone trying to make sense of our rapidly changing world.

Free ebook: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-981-16-8086-1>

Transition and Opportunity: Strategies from Business Leaders on Making the Most of China's Future

Editors: Huiyao Wang and Lu Miao

Publisher: Springer (February 17, 2022)

Multinational corporations (MNCs) have long played a crucial role in the Chinese economy. This role is one that is set to continue in the post-pandemic era as China works to transition to a high-quality growth model that is more sustainable and innovation-driven. With global experience and front-line involvement in some of the most pressing economic, technological, and environmental issues of our day, leading figures in MNCs and chambers of commerce are well placed to share insights that could potentially contribute to policymaking and development strategies so that everyone can “make the most” of China’s future.

This collection of essays aims to share these invaluable insights with a wider audience, offering balanced and diverse perspectives from companies and advocacy groups working on a range of issues related to China’s domestic development, international economic cooperation, and China-US competition. These insights are useful not only for the wider business community, but also for academics, policymakers, students, and anyone trying to deepen their understanding of this exciting period of “transition and opportunity,” to make the most of China’s bright future.

Free ebook: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-981-16-8603-0>

The Asian 21st Century

Author: Kishore Mahbubani

Publisher: Springer (January 1, 2022)

This open access book consists of essays written by Kishore Mahbubani to explore the challenges and dilemmas faced by the West and Asia in an increasingly interdependent world village beset by intensifying geopolitical competition.

The contents cover four parts. Part one discusses the end of the era of Western domination. The major strategic error that the West is now making is to refuse to accept this reality. The West needs to learn how to act strategically in a world where it is no longer the number one. Part two discusses the return of Asia. From the years 1 to 1820, the largest economies in the world were Asian. After the spectacular rise of the West in the 19th and 20th centuries, even great Asian civilizations like China and India were dominated and humiliated. The twenty-first century will see the return of Asia to the center of the world stage. Part three discusses the peaceful rise of China. The shift in the balance of power to the East has been most pronounced in the rise of China. While this rise has been peaceful, many in the West have responded with considerable concern over the influence China will have on the world order. Part four discusses the challenges of globalization, multilateralism, and global cooperation. Many of the world’s pressing issues, such as COVID-19 and climate change, are global issues and will require global cooperation to deal with. In short, human beings now live in a global village. States must work with each other, and we need a world order that enables and facilitates cooperation in our global village.

Free ebook: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-981-16-6811-1>

Consensus or Conflict? China and Globalization in the 21st Century

Editors: Huiyao Wang and Alistair Michie

Publisher: Springer (September 28, 2021)

This open access book brings together leading international scholars and policy-makers to explore the challenges and dilemmas of globalization and governance in an era increasingly defined by economic crises, widespread populism, retreating internationalism, and a looming cold war between the United States and China. It provides the diversity of views on those widely debated topics such as global governance, climate change, global health, migration, S&T revolution, financial market, and sustainable development.

Free ebook: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-981-16-5391-9>

The Chinese Enterprises Globalization Series

This series contributes to the field of globalization and Chinese enterprises studies. It publishes completely up-to-date monographs dedicated to this topic. It also provides a wealth of the latest information regarding Chinese ODI. In addition to this information, the series stands head and shoulders above other work in this area due to its in-depth case studies on Chinese companies going global, all of which are based on thorough primary research.

Get more information at: <https://link.springer.com/series/16146>

The Challenge of “Going Out”

Editors: Huiyao Wang and Lu Miao

Publisher: Springer (November 2, 2023)

In an attempt to make sense of the complex process of adaptation that Chinese enterprises must go through in the course of “going out,” this book provides a multi-dimensional analysis of the driving forces, legal and systemic hurdles, as well as the risks and opportunities that Chinese enterprises must consider as they seek greater fortunes beyond their own borders.

Comprehensive surveys conducted on a range of enterprises provide the foundation for an overview of the current state of Chinese companies operating overseas and developing trends in their overseas investment. Specific topics include key challenges that companies face, their strategies and ultimate goals, as well as their practical experience in investing abroad, especially in Belt and Road countries. Also included are the insightful views of experts, scholars, and entrepreneurs with a wealth of experience in transnational investment in areas related to the globalization of Chinese enterprises, including regional investment risk, overseas talent strategies, legal and

compliance issues, and even the role of technology and the Internet in cross-border e-commerce, just to name a few.

It is our hope that this book will help readers better understand the current state of Chinese enterprises expanding globally, but even more importantly, we hope to provide valuable information for individual enterprises looking to "go out," helping them clarify their investment strategies, make the most of opportunities, manage challenges, and take their business to the next level.

More info: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-981-99-3326-6>

Strategies for Chinese Enterprises Going Global

Editors: Huiyao Wang and Lu Miao

Publisher: Springer (April 5, 2023)

This book carries out comprehensive research on the underlying problems regarding the globalization of Chinese enterprises. It also proposes practical solutions for dealing with difficulties in the legal sphere, legislation, international talent development, and financing solutions for Chinese firms going global. In light of the great opportunities and space for outbound investment, this book also provides insights on how to push forward the Belt and Road Initiative.

The insights herein help readers understand the basic state of Chinese enterprises in overseas development and have important reference value for enterprises looking to gain a better understanding of foreign investment strategies, make the most of opportunities and challenges, and promote their development at a higher level.

More info: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-981-19-6120-5>

The Globalization of Chinese Enterprises: Trends and Characteristics

Editors: Huiyao Wang and Lu Miao

Publisher: Springer (May 22, 2020)

The internationalization of Chinese enterprises is one of the most notable aspects of economic globalization in the 21st century. Despite the 2008 financial crisis and weak global outbound investment, under the "go global" initiative, Chinese outbound investment has gone from strength to strength, while also diversifying in terms of investment modalities, destinations, and industries. However, growing anti-globalization sentiment in some countries has also created new challenges for Chinese firms expanding internationally.

Drawing on nearly 3,000 data samples, using both quantitative and qualitative research methods, this book presents unique insights into the features and patterns of Chinese enterprises' globalization. The analysis provides a useful reference for enterprises that have already gone global and those that plan to. In particular, this book investigates challenges confronted by Chinese companies when doing business in foreign countries. It summarizes research covering three angles, namely: the current situation, causation analysis and corresponding solutions, and recommendations for firms, government agencies, and other institutions.

This book provides a comprehensive overview to help readers to grasp the broad picture of the international expansion of Chinese enterprises. It has important reference value for enterprises to help devise foreign investment strategy, seize opportunities, and navigate challenges in the course of globalization.

More info: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-981-15-4646-4>

International Talent Development in China Series

International talent is a leading force in China's economic globalization. This series features the latest research on international talent development in China, a country that, in recent years, has become the largest source of international education as well as immigration in the world. Topics covered by the series include but are not limited to: international education in China, China's overseas student returnees, China's international population migration, and regional international talent competitiveness in China.

Get more information at: <https://link.springer.com/series/16119>

China's Domestic and International Migration Development

Editors: Huiyao Wang and Lu Miao

Publisher: Springer (March 9, 2019)

This book offers the most comprehensive, up-to-date assessment of China's domestic and international migration. Restructuring economic development requires large numbers of educated and skilled talents, but this effort comes at a time when the size of China's domestic workforce is shrinking. In response, both national and regional governments in China have been keen to encourage overseas Chinese talents and professionals to return to the country. Meanwhile, the Chinese government has initiated a number of policies to attract international highly skilled talent and enhance the country's competitiveness, and some Chinese policies have started attracting foreign talents, who are coming to the country to work, and even to stay. Since Chinese policies, mechanisms, and administration efforts to attract and retain skilled domestic or overseas talents are helping to reshape China's economy and are significantly affecting the cooperation on migration and talent mobility, these aspects, in addition to being of scholarly and research interest, hold considerable commercial potential.

More info: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-981-13-6256-9>

International Migration of China: Status, Policy and Social Responses to the Globalization of Migration

Authors: Lu Miao and Huiyao Wang

Publisher: Springer (August 8, 2017)

This book provides a systemic and detailed monographic study of Chinese outbound migration. It not only breaks down the basic trends of this migration with respect to destinations and the like, but also analyzes its unique features, which include the

largely middle- and upper-class makeup of emigrants and their investment activities overseas, particularly when it comes to buying property. The Chinese are the largest foreign buyers of real estate in the US, Canada, and Australia. By explaining this and other special aspects of Chinese emigration and their impact on China and receiving countries, this book provides a fresh and interesting look at this important phenomenon.

More info: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-981-10-6074-8>

Reverse Migration in Contemporary China: Returnees, Entrepreneurship and the Chinese Economy

Authors: Huiyao Wang and Yue Bao

Publisher: Palgrave Macmillan (October 8, 2015)

The authors investigate the phenomenon of highly skilled Chinese returnees and their impact on the development of the Chinese economy and society, and on the transformation of China into a key player on the global stage. They analyze the reasons why Chinese entrepreneurs choose to return to their native country and how their overseas experience shapes their attitudes and behaviors. This study is solidly grounded on fresh data from online and offline surveys and on evidence collected in over 200 interviews of successful returnee entrepreneurs. These global Chinese returnees have contributed to the rise of the Chinese economy into a global powerhouse and this continuing brain movement and circulation will have much more future implications and impact for China's exchange with the outside world.

More info: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1057/9781137450609>

Other Publications

Escaping Thucydides's Trap: Dialogue with Graham Allison on China-US Relations

Editor & Author: Henry Huiyao Wang

Publisher: Palgrave Macmillan (November 3, 2023)

The book raises questions of how relations between the US and China will unfold, one of the most consequential of the 21st century. In the past decade, perhaps no thinker has had a greater influence on how this question is understood in both the US and China than eminent Harvard scholar Graham Allison, who developed the idea of the Thucydides's Trap to warn of the risk of war erupting between a rising power and a ruling power in the power transition process.

This book presents a comprehensive collection of Allison's views and writings on US-China relations from 2017 to 2022, covering a range of topics including the balance of power between the two sides, where the relationship is headed, and lessons from history on how conflict can be avoided.

The book is presented in an accessible Q&A format and draws on interviews, articles, and reports, as well as dialogues between Professor Allison and Dr. Huiyao

Wang from the Center for China and Globalization (CCG), a non-governmental think tank based in Beijing. The book also includes an introduction and afterword by Dr. Huiyao Wang, CCG president and editor of this volume.

More info: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-981-99-2236-9>

CCG Global Dialogues: Understanding Globalization, Global Gaps, and Power Shifts in the 21st Century

Editors: Huiyao Wang and Lu Miao

Publisher: Palgrave Macmillan (November 24, 2022)

This open access book aims to help readers make sense of our changing world by sharing the views of global thought leaders on some of the most important issues of our time, from US-China relations and global governance to climate change and the COVID-19 pandemic.

The ten dialogues in this book were part of the “China and the World” series of online discussions hosted by the Center for China and Globalization (CCG). The series features CCG President Huiyao Wang in conversation with experts from a range of fields, from renowned scholars of international relations, economics, and history, to journalists, policymakers, and business leaders.

The speakers featured in this book are Graham Allison, David Blair, Kerry Brown, Anne Case, Li Chen, Wendy Cutler, Angus Deaton, Thomas L. Friedman, Valerie Hansen, Pascal Lamy, Kishore Mahbubani, Joseph S. Nye Jr., Adam Posen, J. Stapleton Roy, John L. Thornton, Huiyao Wang, Martin Wolf, and Zhu Guangyao.

These wide-ranging discussions offer unique insights and perspectives on key trends shaping our world in the 21st century. These include the rise of China and shifts in geopolitics, as well as the evolving nature of globalization, transnational threats, and multilateralism.

Free ebook: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-981-19-3846-7>

China Goes Global: The Impact of Chinese Overseas Investment on its Business Enterprises

Authors: Huiyao Wang and Lu Miao

Publisher: Palgrave Macmillan (March 8, 2016)

Mainland China businesses are going global, transforming the country from a manufacturing export platform into an overseas investment powerhouse. *China Goes Global* is the most thorough and up-to-date empirical analysis of the accelerating effort of Chinese companies to go global by investing overseas. It details the overall trends of this activity with respect to its sectors, channels, overseas targets, and particular firms, along with the role of Chinese government policy in facilitating business enterprise globalization. The book offers readers an enterprise level view of outward expansion by Chinese firms that is focused not only on the big names, but also on the less well-known, but equally important trailblazing enterprises. In doing so it offers practical suggestions on how firms can tackle the challenges encountered when expanding outward.

More info: <https://link.springer.com/book/10.1007/978-1-137-57813-6>